



**MET ASIAN MANAGEMENT
DEVELOPMENT CENTRE**

DISSERTATION PROJECT REPORT ON

**The Authenticity Gap: A Strategic Audit of Brand Perception vs. Consumer
Decision-Making Logic among Gen Z in India's D2C Fashion Sector.**

**SUBMITTED IN PARTIAL FULFILLMENT FOR THE AWARD OF THE DEGREE OF
POST GRADUATE PROGRAMME EMPOWERED MANAGEMENT & BUSINESS
ADMINISTRATION (PGP EMBA)**

SUBMITTED BY:

HAJI RAYYAAN TAJ

ROLL NO: 2440

MARKETING AND BUSINESS ANALYTIC

PGP EMBA 2024 - 26

UNDER THE GUIDANCE OF

MR. SAMEER CHARANIA SIR & MS. MITALI SANKHE

MUMBAI EDUCATIONAL TRUST

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DECLARATION

I, **Mr. Haji Rayyaan Taj** studying in the **PGP EMBA Second Year** at the **MET's Asian Management Development Centre**, Bandra, Mumbai hereby declare that I have completed the Dissertation Project titled **“The Authenticity Gap: A Strategic Audit of Brand Perception vs. Consumer Decision-Making Logic among Gen Z in India's D2C Fashion Sector.”** “As a part of the curriculum requirement for the program name.

I also declare that the work undertaken by me is original and has not been copied from any source. I further declare that the information presented in this project report is true and has not been submitted to any other Institute for any other examination.

Place:

(Signature of the Student)

Date: DD/MM/YYYY

Haji Rayyaan Taj

AI USAGE DECLARATION

This dissertation project is substantially based on the author's original academic work, including the research design, primary data collection, data analysis, interpretation of findings, and conclusions drawn from the study.

Artificial Intelligence tools were used in a limited and supportive role throughout the duration of the project. The use of AI was confined to improving structural organization, refining academic language, enhancing clarity of expression, and supporting the effective communication of ideas originally developed by the author. AI assistance was also used as a secondary review mechanism to help reorganize the author's existing thoughts, remove redundancy, and improve logical flow across sections.

In relation to data-related work, AI support was used during questionnaire refinement by assisting in the elimination of redundant or overlapping questions from the author's original questionnaire, thereby improving clarity and focus while retaining the original intent. During data interpretation, AI tools were used to help articulate and structure the author's interpretations more clearly for academic presentation. AI did not generate primary data, independent insights, analytical outcomes, or conclusions.

Any content influenced by AI tools was carefully reviewed, edited, and approved by the author prior to inclusion. The meaning, logic, and substance of the analysis remained under the author's full control, and no AI-generated content was accepted without critical evaluation and modification.

The use of Artificial Intelligence was conducted within the academic guidelines permitted by the institution, where AI is allowed as an assistive tool but not as a substitute for original research or authorship. The author accepts full responsibility for the originality, accuracy, and academic integrity of the work presented in this dissertation.

(Signature of the Student)

Haji Rayyaan Taj

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I also acknowledge the cooperation and participation of all individuals who contributed directly or indirectly to this study. Their inputs, responses, and support were essential in completing the research effectively.

Finally, I acknowledge the learning environment provided by **MET Asian Management Development Centre**, which enabled the successful completion of this dissertation as part of the academic curriculum.

Regards,

(Signature of the Student)

Haji Rayyaan Taj

CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that **Mr. Haji Ravyaan Taj** studying in the **PGP EMBA Second Year** at the **MET Asian Management Development Centre**, Bandra, Mumbai has completed the Dissertation Project titled “**The Authenticity Gap: A Strategic Audit of Brand Perception vs. Consumer Decision-Making Logic among Gen Z in India’s D2C Fashion Sector.**”

” as a part of the curriculum requirement. During the Fourth Semester, in the partial fulfilment of the Post Graduate Programme Empowered Management and Business Administration for the Academic Year 2025-2026. **Bearing Roll No. 2440**

This project work is original and was not submitted earlier for any award of any degree/diploma or associated with any other Institute / University.

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MR. SAMEER CHARANIA SIR & MS. MITALI SANKHE

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Mr. Arun Patil
Dean, MET AMDC

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation audits the authenticity gap between Indian direct-to-consumer (D2C) fashion brands' projected messaging and how Gen Z consumers evaluate and decide. The study uses an exploratory descriptive design based on a self-designed questionnaire administered to a purposive-convenience sample of 112 Mumbai-based respondents, data collected from 1 January 2025 to 31 January 2025. Descriptive statistics and thematic analysis were applied to closed and open responses respectively.

Key findings

- Visual aesthetics and product design dominate initial discovery, with Instagram functioning as the primary framing platform.
- Customer reviews and product quality drive final purchase decisions; influencer endorsements lose persuasive power at conversion.
- Perception gaps form when polished messaging, influencer amplification, or premium positioning exceed delivered product experience. Three quarters of respondents reported withdrawing trust after an image–reality mismatch.
- Gen Z defines authenticity in operational terms: consistent delivery, transparent communication, and verifiable peer feedback.

Managerial implications

- Align pricing and presentation with measurable product performance.
- Reduce reliance on influencer volume until brand identity and delivery consistency are proven.
- Prioritise genuine customer feedback, honest product imagery, and service reliability to lower returns and improve retention.

The research reframes authenticity as an observable decision variable and provides actionable steps for closing the gap between brand projection and consumer trust.

INTRODUCTION:

India's direct to consumer (D2C) fashion sector has changed fast since 2020, mainly because a few things came together at the same time. Smartphone usage became mass level, UPI made payments simple, and last mile logistics players like Delhivery and Ecom Express expanded across the country. All this reduced the old entry barriers for consumer brands. At the same time social media stopped being only a branding platform and started working as a full funnel channel for discovery and sales. As marketplaces became more expensive and heavily algorithm driven, many brands started moving towards owning demand, customer data, and margins through D2C models. Venture capital also pushed this shift by focusing more on brand ownership, pricing control, and long-term equity instead of distributor led scale.

This change is visible in how large FMCG and consumer goods companies now look at D2C brands. Investments and acquisitions like Hindustan Unilever taking a stake in Minimalist, Marico acquiring Plix, Emami gaining control of The Man Company, and ITC acquiring Yoga Bar show how D2C brands are no longer treated as experiments. They are seen as strategic assets. These moves place the D2C fashion sector at the centre of understanding modern brand building, consumer trust, and decision making in India.

Within this space, Gen Z consumers form a separate and strong group. Older fashion buyers often depend on brand history, store presence, or long-standing reputation. Gen Z works differently. Their discovery and evaluation are mostly driven by algorithms. Platforms like Instagram and YouTube act as discovery engines where content, creators, peer styling, and social validation come before brand awareness. Trust is built through proof rather than reputation. User generated content, reviews, fit videos, return experiences, and public brand replies matter more than celebrity endorsements or years of existence. Physical stores for Gen Z work more as experience and validation points, not the main decision drivers.

This shift makes authenticity a serious issue in branding. In the current D2C fashion market, many brands call themselves premium, ethical, or value driven but fail to stay consistent across pricing, product quality, influencer usage, sustainability claims, and post purchase experience. Founder stories, creator partnerships, and value-based messaging start losing credibility when they feel scripted, exaggerated, or disconnected from actual operations. Fast trend copying, shallow community building, and heavy influencer dependence weaken brand identity further. For Gen Z, authenticity is not a one-time claim. It is something they keep checking, constantly and publicly.

A major problem comes from the way many Indian D2C fashion brands focus more on image than on experience consistency. Visual storytelling, influencer reach, and launch hype often get more attention than basics like sizing accuracy, delivery timelines, product quality, and customer support. This creates a gap between what the brand promises and what the customer experiences. Over time this gap leads to scepticism and disengagement.

From a marketing point of view, these gaps create long term risk. In a category where consumers cannot touch or try the product before buying, trust becomes critical for repeat purchases and word of mouth. When messaging promises more than the experience delivers, return rates go up, customer lifetime value drops, and acquisition costs rise. Gradually, consumer perception starts dominating over intended positioning, making performance ads and influencer visibility less effective. This pressure has already forced several D2C brands to move into physical retail to rebuild confidence and reduce uncertainty.

Against this background, this study focuses more on practical use for marketers and brand managers rather than theory. By looking at how Gen Z consumers read brand messaging, judge authenticity, and turn perception into purchase decisions, the study aims to produce insights that help improve communication, experience design, and trust building. The core problem addressed is the gap between how Indian D2C fashion brands project authenticity and how Gen Z consumers actually perceive, evaluate, and act on these claims while making purchase decisions.

OBJECTIVES:

The primary objective of this study is to enable Indian D2C fashion brands to clearly identify, understand, and address the gaps between their projected brand messaging and how Gen Z consumers actually perceive, interpret, and respond to those messages, with the aim of strengthening trust, reducing disengagement and brand switching, and supporting sustainable long term brand growth.

In support of this primary objective, the study is designed with the following specific objectives.

1. The first objective is to examine the decision-making behaviour of Gen Z consumers in the context of Indian D2C fashion brands. This includes understanding how Gen Z consumers evaluate brands at different stages of the purchase journey, the cues they rely on while forming judgments, and the factors that ultimately influence whether they proceed with or withdraw from a purchase. The focus is on how messaging, perceived authenticity, and brand signals shape these decisions before and during engagement with the brand.
2. The second objective is to identify and analyse perception gaps between brand communication and consumer interpretation. This involves assessing how Gen Z consumers decode brand messaging, tone, visual presentation, influencer associations, and value-based narratives, and where these interpretations diverge from the intended positioning of D2C fashion brands. The study seeks to highlight areas where messaging creates confusion, scepticism, or unmet expectations.
3. The third objective is to explore how consistency between brand promise and perceived behaviour influences trust formation among Gen Z consumers. Particular emphasis is placed on evaluating whether brands are seen as aligning their stated values, positioning claims, and external communication with their observed actions, responses, and conduct in public digital spaces. The study also examines how misalignment weakens credibility over time.
4. The fourth objective is to explicitly examine disengagement and brand switching behaviour as outcomes of perceived inauthenticity and trust erosion. This includes identifying stages at which Gen Z consumers lose interest, the reasons behind withdrawal or avoidance, and the role of exaggerated claims, influencer overuse, value misalignment, or inconsistent experiences in driving exit behaviour.
5. The fifth objective is to assess the role of brand values and behaviour alignment in shaping Gen Z perceptions of authenticity. This involves understanding how Gen Z evaluates claims related to inclusivity, transparency, cultural awareness, and ethical positioning, and how inconsistencies in these areas influence long term engagement.

6. The final objective is to develop practical, actionable recommendations for D2C fashion brands and marketing agencies. These recommendations are intended to guide improvements in brand communication strategy, authenticity signalling, and consumer engagement approaches, from the perspective of a brand manager seeking to align messaging with Gen Z expectations and decision logic.

Together, these objectives position the study as a practical, insight driven examination of how authenticity perception influences decision making, trust, disengagement, and brand sustainability within India's D2C fashion sector.

THE REVIEW OF LITRATURE:

The rise of Gen Z as a dominant consumer cohort has reshaped how brands are discovered, evaluated, and trusted, particularly within digital first and D2C markets. Existing literature over the last five years emphasizes that Gen Z consumers differ structurally from previous generations in their information processing, attention patterns, and evaluation criteria. Studies highlight that Gen Z relies heavily on algorithm driven platforms such as Instagram and YouTube for discovery, where content exposure precedes brand awareness and where peer validation plays a critical role in shaping initial attitudes. Research conducted in the Indian context indicates that Gen Z consumers exhibit low reliance on brand heritage and high sensitivity to social proof, public feedback, and perceived transparency, making them less forgiving of inconsistency and exaggeration.

A growing body of research links Gen Z behaviour to heightened expectations of authenticity in branding. Brand authenticity is commonly defined as the perception that a brand is genuine, transparent, and consistent in its actions and communication. Recent studies argue that authenticity has shifted from being a symbolic attribute to an operational one, where consumers continuously verify whether brand claims align with observable behaviour. In the Indian D2C context, authenticity is increasingly evaluated through pricing logic, sourcing claims, influencer associations, and responsiveness to public criticism. Research suggests that when brands rely heavily on scripted storytelling or trend driven narratives without operational backing, Gen Z consumers develop scepticism rather than affinity.

Brand perception gaps have emerged as a recurring theme in contemporary branding literature. Perception gaps refer to the divergence between intended brand positioning and consumer interpreted meaning. Studies indicate that digital first brands are particularly vulnerable to such gaps due to the speed and scale at which messaging is distributed across platforms. In India's D2C fashion sector, perception gaps are amplified by influencer led communication, rapid trend adoption, and short campaign cycles. Research highlights that Gen Z consumers interpret tone, visuals, and creator associations as indicators of brand intent, often overriding official brand messaging. When these signals conflict, consumers default to scepticism, which weakens credibility.

The literature on D2C and digital first brand models emphasize the strategic advantage of owning customer relationships, data, and margins. Indian market studies show that D2C brands gained momentum post 2020 due to reduced entry barriers, digital payment adoption, and social commerce growth. However, research also notes that while D2C models enable direct communication, they increase accountability. Without

intermediaries, brand messaging, experience delivery, and customer response are directly attributed to the brand, increasing reputational risk. This structural exposure makes authenticity and consistency critical for sustaining engagement in D2C fashion.

Trust formation remains a foundational concept in branding literature, though recent research reframes trust as dynamic rather than static. Traditional models viewed trust as built through repeated satisfactory experiences over time. Newer studies argue that for Gen Z, trust forms rapidly through social verification and dissolves quickly when contradictions surface. Indian studies indicate that public complaint handling, transparency in return policies, and visible corrective action influence trust more than formal assurances. Trust is therefore less about long term reputation and more about real time behavioural consistency.

Influencer marketing literature presents mixed findings. While several studies acknowledge influencers as effective discovery agents, recent research cautions against overreliance. Excessive influencer use has been linked to credibility dilution, particularly when partnerships appear transactional or repetitive. Indian market reports note rising influencer fatigue among Gen Z consumers, who increasingly question authenticity and paid promotion transparency. Literature suggests that influencer credibility depends on perceived alignment, disclosure clarity, and restraint rather than volume.

Despite extensive research across these domains, clear gaps remain. Existing studies often examine brand perception, authenticity, influencer marketing, and trust in isolation. There is limited integration of these constructs to explain how perception gaps translate into disengagement or brand switching behaviour, particularly within India's D2C fashion sector. Much of the influencer literature emphasizes effectiveness without adequately addressing trust erosion. Additionally, India focused Gen Z studies remain underrepresented relative to Western markets, despite distinct cultural, economic, and platform dynamics.

This study addresses these gaps by linking Gen Z decision making behaviour with authenticity perception, brand messaging interpretation, and disengagement outcomes within the Indian D2C fashion context. By grounding established branding theories in contemporary digital first realities, the research contributes context specific insight relevant to both academic inquiry and practical brand strategy.

METHODOLOGY:

This study adopts an exploratory descriptive research design to examine how Gen Z consumers interpret brand messaging and authenticity cues in India's D2C fashion sector, and how these interpretations influence decision making, disengagement, and brand switching behaviour. The design is appropriate for understanding patterns, perceptions, and behavioural tendencies in a rapidly evolving market context without attempting hypothesis testing or causal inference.

Primary data was collected using a structured questionnaire administered through Google Forms. The online format enabled efficient reach, consistency in question presentation, and ease of response for digitally active Gen Z participants. The questionnaire contained a mix of closed ended questions, Likert scale items, multiple choice questions, and open-ended questions to capture both measurable patterns and nuanced consumer narratives.

A combination of convenience and purposive sampling was used. Convenience sampling formed the base, with respondents approached through accessible networks and face to face outreach supported by Google Form links. Purposive filtering was applied through screening questions to ensure relevance to the study objectives. Only respondents who met predefined criteria related to age and recent D2C fashion purchase behaviour were included in the final sample.

The geographic scope of the study was limited to Mumbai. This location was selected due to high exposure to D2C fashion brands, dense digital media consumption, and strong representation of Gen Z consumers engaged with online fashion content and brand communication.

Data collection was conducted over a one-month period from 1 January 2025 to 31 January 2025. A total of 126 responses were initially collected during this period. After screening and data cleaning, 112 responses were retained for final analysis.

The inclusion criteria for respondents were clearly defined. Participants were required to be between 18 and 25 years of age, based in India, and to have purchased from an Indian D2C fashion brand within the last six months. Respondents were also expected to be aware of D2C fashion brands and actively engage with online fashion related content and brand communication channels.

Exclusion criteria included respondents outside the 18 to 25 age range, individuals who had never purchased from a D2C fashion brand, and those whose most recent D2C fashion purchase occurred more than one year prior to the survey. Responses failing to meet these criteria were removed to maintain relevance and consistency.

Data screening and cleaning involved reviewing all submitted forms for completeness and validity. Incomplete responses, blank submissions, and entries that did not satisfy screening conditions were excluded. From the initial 126 responses, 14 were removed due to non-completion or invalid entries, resulting in a final usable sample of 112 responses for analysis.

Both descriptive and qualitative analytical techniques were used. Descriptive statistics were applied to closed ended questions to summarize response distributions and identify observable trends related to brand perception, trust cues, and decision-making factors. Open ended responses were analysed using thematic analysis, where recurring patterns, meanings, and authenticity related perceptions were identified and grouped into coherent themes.

Multiple tools were used to support analysis and presentation. Google Forms was used for survey creation and initial data collection. Microsoft Excel was used for data cleaning, formatting, and preliminary analysis. Python was used for structured data analysis, and Power BI was used for dashboarding and visual representation of key insights to support interpretation.

Limitations of the study should be acknowledged. The research is limited to a single city, which may affect broader generalization across India. The use of convenience-based sampling introduces potential selection bias. Responses are self-reported and may be influenced by recall bias or subjective interpretation. The study focuses on perception and decision logic rather than objective measurement of product quality or operational performance. Despite these limitations, the methodology is appropriate for exploratory insight generation aligned with the objectives of the study.

QUESTIONNAIRE:

This questionnaire was self-designed for the purpose of the present study titled The Authenticity Gap. A Strategic Audit of Brand Perception versus Consumer Decision Making Logic among Gen Z in India's D2C Fashion Sector. The instrument was used to collect primary data from Gen Z consumers to understand brand perception, authenticity evaluation, trust formation, and decision-making behaviour in the Indian D2C fashion context.

The questionnaire consists of five sections. All responses were collected anonymously through an online Google Form.

Definition Provided to Respondents

Direct to Consumer fashion brands are brands that sell clothing directly to customers through their own websites or mobile applications instead of selling through physical stores or third-party marketplaces. These brands typically promote products through social media platforms, digital advertising, influencer collaborations, and online content. Customers purchase directly from the brand online.

Examples of Indian D2C fashion brands include The Souled Store, Bewakoof, Snitch, Blissclub, Bombay Shirt Company, and Veirdo.

SECTION 1. DEMOGRAPHIC PROFILE AND PURCHASE SCREENING

Q1. What is your age group

18 to 20

21 to 23

24 to 25

Q2. Current status

Student

Working professional

Both

Q3. Approximate monthly spending on fashion

Below ₹2,000

₹2,000 to ₹5,000

₹5,001 to ₹10,000

Above ₹10,000

Q4. Have you purchased from any Indian D2C fashion brand in the last six months

Yes

No

SECTION 2. BRAND AWARENESS AND DISCOVERY

Q5. Which Indian D2C fashion brands come to your mind first

(Please mention up to three brands)

Q6. How did you first discover these brands

Select all that apply

Instagram or social media

Influencer content

Online advertisements

Friends or word of mouth

Search or browsing

Other

Q7. What made you notice or remember these brands initially

Select up to three options

Visual aesthetics

Messaging or tone

Product design

Pricing

Brand story or values

Popularity or hype

Other

Q8. On first impression, how appealing do most D2C fashion brands feel to you

1 Not appealing

2

3

4

5 Very appealing

SECTION 3. BRAND MESSAGING AND PERCEPTION

Q9. How would you describe the general communication style of D2C fashion brands today

Select up to three options

Relatable

Trend focused

Honest

Over promotional

Artificial or scripted

Other

Q10. To what extent does brand messaging match the actual product or service experience

1 Does not match at all

2

3

4

5 Matches completely

Q11. How often do you feel D2C brands exaggerate or overpromise in their marketing

Very often

Often

Sometimes

Rarely

Never

Q12. Which platform influences your perception of a D2C fashion brand the most

Instagram

Brand website

Influencers

Customer reviews

Friends or peers

Other

Q13. Do you feel D2C brands are mostly talking with you or talking at you

Talking with me

Talking at me

Depends on the brand

Other

SECTION 4. TRUST FORMATION AND DECISION LOGIC

Q14. Which factors most influence your purchase decision from a D2C fashion brand

Select up to three options

Product quality

Brand image

Customer reviews

Price

Perceived honesty

Influencer credibility

Q15. What do you trust most while deciding to purchase from a D2C brand

Customer reviews

Brand's own content

Influencer recommendations

Friends' opinions

Other

Q16. At which stage do you most commonly lose interest in a D2C fashion brand

After seeing advertisements

While browsing the website

After checking reviews

After receiving the product

Q17. How important is authenticity in your fashion purchase decisions

1 Not important

2

3

4

5 Extremely important

Q18. Have you ever stopped trusting or engaging with a brand due to a mismatch between image and reality

Yes

No

Q19. How do you feel about heavy influencer marketing by D2C fashion brands

Very tolerant

Neutral

Increasingly sceptical

Strongly dislike it

SECTION 5. CONSUMER INSIGHTS AND STRATEGIC FEEDBACK

Q20. In your own words, what does an authentic fashion brand mean to you

Q21. What makes a D2C fashion brand feel inauthentic or fake (Select up to three options).

Overuse of influencers

Exaggerated or misleading claims

Poor product quality compared to advertisements

Fake or paid reviews

Copying trends without originality

Inconsistent brand tone or messaging

Unrealistic body images or styling

Overly sales driven content

Claiming values they do not follow

Other

Q22. Think about your most recent D2C fashion purchase. What finally convinced you to buy

Positive customer reviews

Product design or style

Price or discount

Trust in the brand

Honest product images or videos

Recommendation from friends

Influencer promotion

Brand values or story

Other

Q23. Have you ever stopped buying from a D2C fashion brand you once liked

Yes

No

Q24. If yes, what was the main reason for stopping

Product quality did not match expectations

Misleading marketing

Price not worth the value

Too much influencer promotion

Lost trust in the brand

Poor customer service

Delivery or return issues

Q25. What do you think most Indian D2C fashion brands get wrong about Gen Z

Trying too hard to appear cool

Overusing influencers

Focusing more on hype than quality

Lack of transparency

Assuming trends automatically build trust

Ignoring long term relationship building

Not listening to customer feedback

Other

Q26. If you were advising a D2C fashion brand, what is one thing they should stop doing immediately

DATA INTERPRETATION & ANALYSIS:

This chapter presents a systematic analysis and interpretation of the primary data collected for the study, based on 112 valid responses obtained from Gen Z consumers. All responses were reviewed, cleaned, and retained for analysis, as no incomplete submissions, critical missing values, or invalid response patterns were identified during the data validation process. The dataset is therefore considered fully usable and reliable for exploratory interpretation.

The purpose of this chapter is to examine patterns in Gen Z consumer perceptions, evaluations, and behavioural tendencies toward Indian D2C fashion brands, using empirical evidence gathered through the structured questionnaire. The analysis focuses on identifying recurring trends, perceptual alignments and mismatches, and decision-making cues that shape how authenticity is interpreted and acted upon by this consumer group.

The chapter employs descriptive analysis to summarize and interpret responses from closed ended questions, alongside thematic analysis of open-ended responses to capture deeper consumer narratives. Findings are explicitly interpreted in relation to the stated research objectives to maintain analytical coherence and ensure alignment between data, objectives, and outcomes.

To maintain clarity and structure, the analysis is organized into five sections corresponding to the five sections of the questionnaire. Each section highlights key observations relevant to the study objectives, with emphasis placed on explaining patterns and relationships observed in the data rather than advancing strategic recommendations, which are addressed in the concluding chapter.

Section 1: Demographic Profile and Purchase Screening

This section outlines the demographic composition and purchase context of respondents to establish their relevance and credibility for the study. Understanding who the respondents are, their engagement with fashion, and their recent exposure to D2C brands provides the foundation for interpreting subsequent findings related to brand perception and decision making.

Question 1: age group distribution

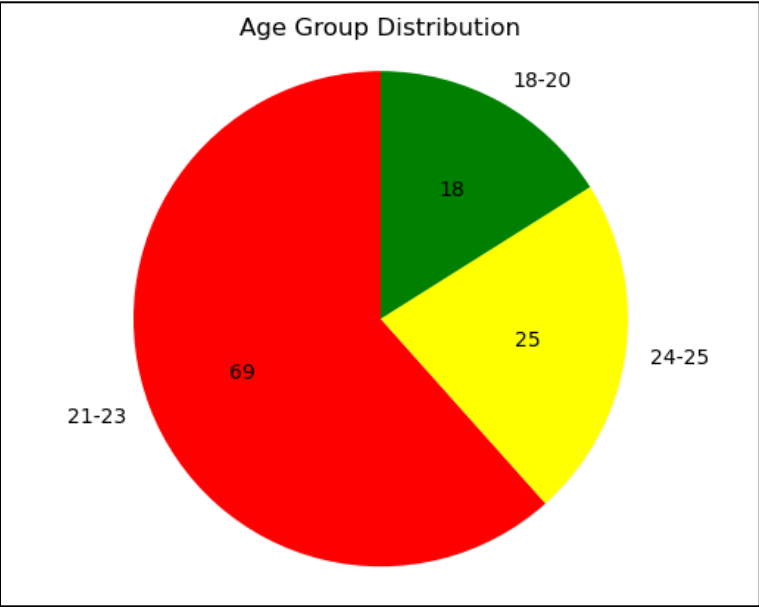


Figure 1

Age Group Distribution

The age group distribution shows that the majority of respondents fall within the 21–23 age bracket, followed by the 24–25 group, with a smaller representation from the 18–20 segment. This indicates that the sample is concentrated within the core Gen Z age range most actively engaged with digital platforms and online fashion consumption.

Respondents in the 21–23 and 24–25 age groups typically exhibit higher exposure to D2C fashion brands, greater familiarity with online purchasing, and increasing decision autonomy. The inclusion of younger respondents aged 18–20 ensures representation of early Gen Z consumers who are highly influenced by social media driven discovery. Overall, the age distribution confirms that the respondent profile is appropriate for examining Gen Z perceptions, authenticity evaluation, and decision-making behaviour in the Indian D2C fashion context.

Question 2: What is your current status?

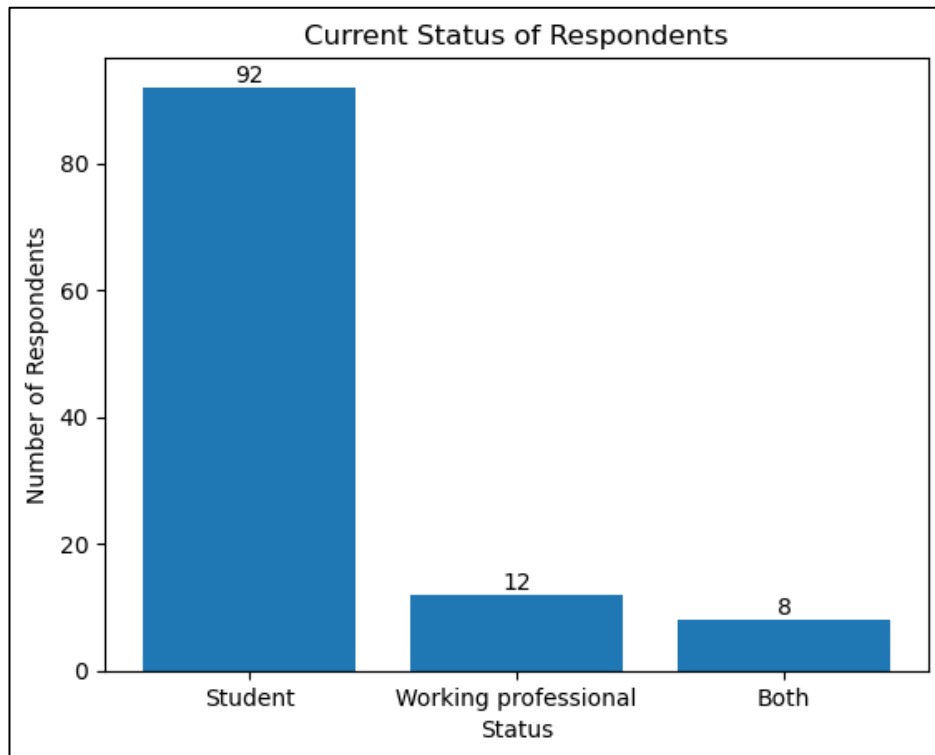


Figure 2

Current Status of Respondents

The distribution of respondents by current status indicates that the sample is predominantly composed of students, with a smaller proportion of working professionals and individuals who identify as both studying and working. This reflects the demographic profile of Gen Z in the selected age range, where formal education remains the primary engagement for a large segment of the cohort.

The dominance of students suggests high exposure to digital platforms, social media content, and peer driven fashion influence, which are central to D2C brand discovery and perception. At the same time, the presence of working professionals and respondents balancing both roles introduces variation by incorporating perspectives shaped by income responsibility, value assessment, and post purchase evaluation.

Overall, the distribution confirms that the respondent group represents digitally active Gen Z consumers with differing levels of financial independence, making the sample appropriate for examining decision making behaviour and brand perception in the D2C fashion context. Given this level of digital exposure, the manner in which these consumers encounter and discover D2C fashion brands becomes a critical factor for further analysis.

Question 3: what is your Approximate monthly spending on fashion?

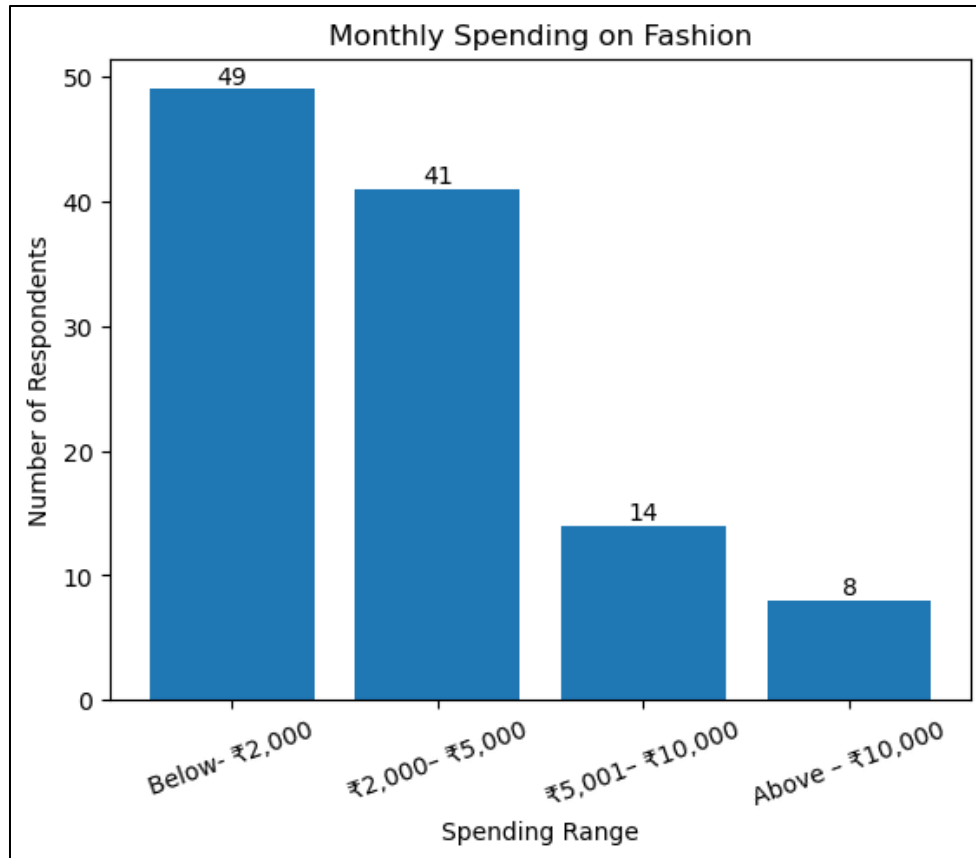


Figure 3

Monthly Fashion Spending

The monthly fashion spending distribution shows that the majority of respondents fall within the lower to mid spending brackets, with most reporting expenditure below ₹5,000 per month. A smaller proportion of respondents report moderate spending between ₹5,001 and ₹10,000, while only a limited number fall into the highest spending category above ₹10,000.

This pattern reflects the broader respondent profile observed earlier, where a large share of participants are students. Limited discretionary income among students is therefore mirrored in lower monthly fashion expenditure, reinforcing the value conscious nature of the sample. Despite this constraint, respondents continue to engage actively with fashion purchases, indicating regular category involvement rather than occasional or infrequent buying.

The presence of respondents with moderate and higher spending levels introduces additional depth to the sample, capturing Gen Z consumers who are willing to spend selectively when perceived quality, brand alignment, or authenticity expectations are met. Taken together, the spending distribution highlights a cohort that balances price sensitivity with evaluative judgment, a combination that is particularly relevant for analysing decision making and perception formation in the D2C fashion context.

This spending profile further underscores the importance of how D2C brands position value, pricing, and authenticity cues, which directly influences how such consumers respond to brand discovery and communication.

Question 4: Have you purchased from any Indian D2C fashion brand in the last 6 months?

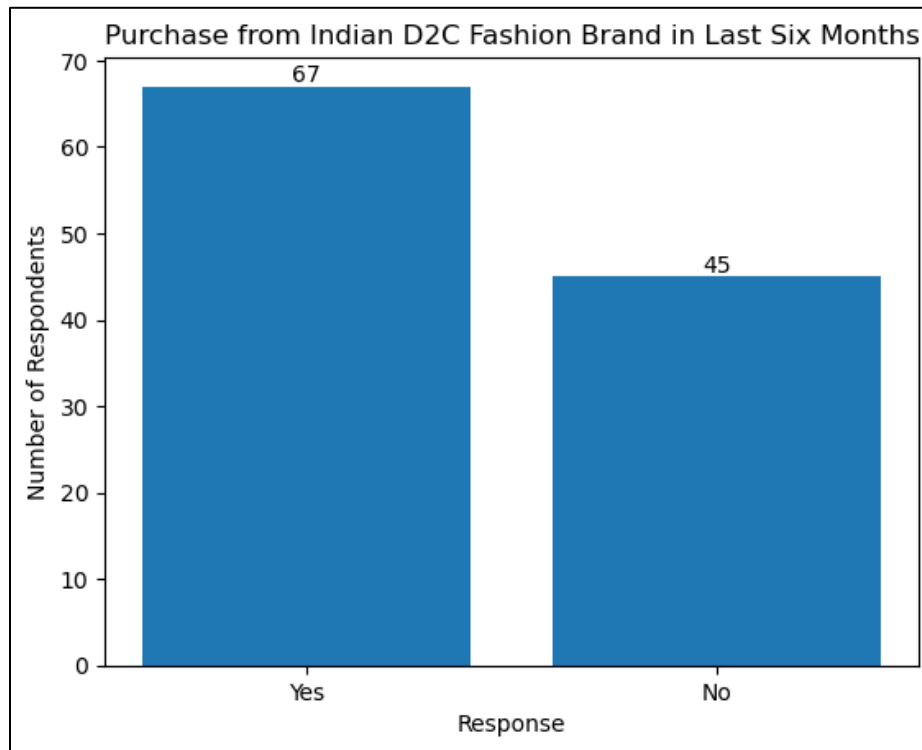


Figure 4

Recent D2C Fashion Purchase Exposure

The responses indicate that a majority of participants reported purchasing from an Indian D2C fashion brand within the last six months, while a smaller segment reported no purchase within this period. This question was designed to assess purchase recency rather than to function as a strict exclusion criterion.

To maintain the relevance of the study, respondents who selected “No” were included only if they had purchased from an Indian D2C fashion brand within the last one year. Individuals who had never purchased from a D2C fashion brand, or whose most recent purchase exceeded one year, were not allowed to proceed with the survey. As a result, all respondents included in the final analysis possessed direct and relatively recent experience with Indian D2C fashion brands.

This screening approach ensures that subsequent analysis of brand perception, authenticity evaluation, and decision-making behaviour is grounded in actual consumer experience rather than hypothetical assessment.

Section 1 Summary

The demographic and purchase profile of respondents establishes a strong and credible foundation for the analysis that follows. The study draws insights from digitally active Gen Z consumers, predominantly students, who are deeply embedded in online environments and engage regularly with fashion related content and purchases. Their age, current status, and spending patterns collectively indicate a cohort that is both highly exposed to D2C brand communication and actively involved in evaluating fashion brands within realistic budget constraints.

The spending distribution further reflects a value conscious mindset, where respondents balance frequent engagement with sensitivity to price and perceived value. At the same time, the presence of respondents with moderate and higher spending capacity adds depth by capturing variation in purchase motivation and evaluative rigor. Importantly, all respondents included in the analysis possess recent and direct experience with Indian D2C fashion brands, ensuring that their perceptions and judgments are grounded in actual brand interaction rather than abstract opinion.

Taken together, this respondent profile supports the validity of the dataset for examining how Gen Z consumers navigate the D2C fashion landscape. With a clear understanding of who the respondents are and why their perspectives are relevant, the analysis now shifts focus to the initial stage of the consumer journey, specifically how these consumers become aware of and discover D2C fashion brands.

SECTION 2: BRAND AWARENESS AND DISCOVERY

This section examines how Gen Z consumers become aware of and initially encounter Indian D2C fashion brands. After establishing the relevance and credibility of the respondent profile in the previous section, the analysis now shifts to the earliest stage of the consumer journey, namely brand recall, discovery, and first impression formation.

The questions in this section explore which D2C fashion brands come to mind first, the channels through which these brands are discovered, and the specific cues that capture attention during initial exposure. Understanding these early touchpoints is critical, as brand awareness and discovery shape the context in which subsequent messaging is interpreted and evaluated. The section also assesses the overall appeal of D2C fashion brands at the first impression stage, providing a baseline for analysing how perception evolves into trust or scepticism in later stages of the decision-making process.

Question 5: Which Indian D2C fashion brands come to your mind first ?

	Brand Name	Mentions
0	souled store	27
1	snitch	25
2	bewakoof	16
3	boat	9
4	bonkers	7
5	zara	6
6	bombay shirt company	6
7	westside	6
8	lenskart	5
9	zudio	5
10	offduty	5
11	bata	4
12	nykaa	4
13	libas	3
14	damensch	3
15	powerlook	2
16	hrx	2
17	wrogn	2
18	jockey	1

Figure 5

Top of Mind Recall of Indian D2C Fashion Brands

Responses to the open-ended brand recall question reveal a clear concentration of top-of-mind awareness around a limited set of Indian D2C fashion brands. Brands such as The Souled Store, Snitch, and Bewakoof received the highest number of mentions, indicating strong recall among Gen Z consumers. These brands appear to occupy a dominant position in the mental consideration set during the initial stage of brand awareness.

Beyond the most frequently mentioned names, a long tail of brands received fewer mentions, including both D2C focused brands and hybrid or retail led brands. This suggests that while a small number of D2C brands have succeeded in achieving strong cognitive visibility, brand awareness across the broader D2C fashion landscape remains fragmented.

The presence of brands operating across adjacent categories such as footwear, accessories, and lifestyle further indicates that Gen Z recall is shaped less by strict category boundaries and more by overall digital visibility and content exposure. Top of mind recall in this context reflects repeated exposure through digital channels rather than deliberate brand evaluation.

This pattern highlights that brand awareness among Gen Z is selective and concentrated, with a few brands benefiting from sustained visibility while many others struggle to achieve spontaneous recall. This concentration of awareness forms the starting point for understanding how discovery channels and attention triggers influence which brands progress from awareness to deeper evaluation.

Question 6: How did you first discover these brands

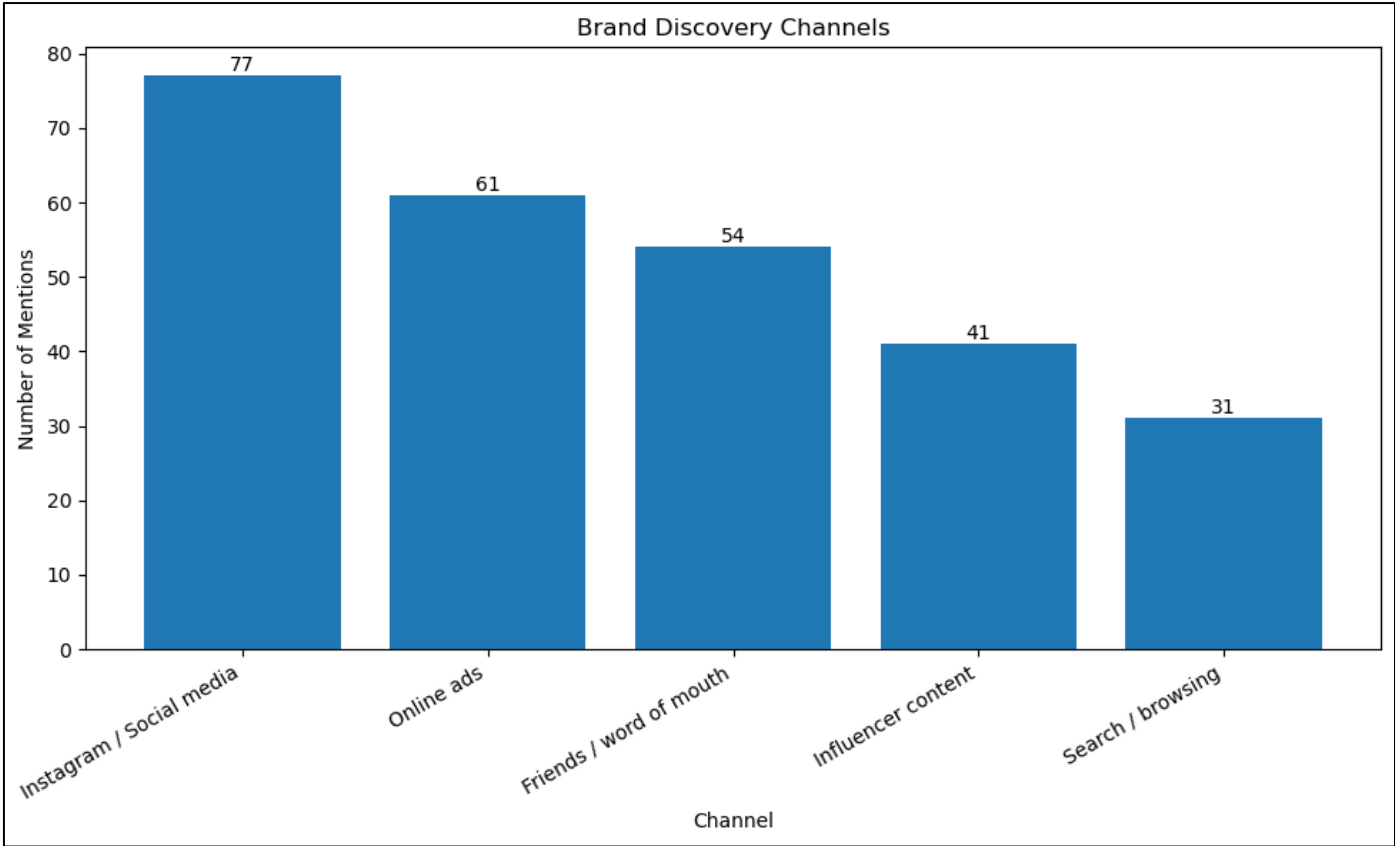


Figure 6

Brand Discovery Channels

The analysis of brand discovery channels indicates that social media platforms, particularly Instagram and similar content driven networks, play the most dominant role in introducing Indian D2C fashion brands to Gen Z consumers. This is followed closely by online advertisements and peer driven word of mouth, while influencer content and active search or browsing appear as secondary discovery routes.

This distribution is closely linked to the respondent profile identified earlier. With a majority of respondents being students, sustained engagement with social platforms forms a central part of their daily media consumption. As a result, brand discovery occurs primarily through algorithm driven feeds where fashion brands are encountered alongside entertainment, peer content, and lifestyle media rather than through deliberate brand search.

The strong presence through online advertisements as a discovery channel reflects the aggressive digital advertising strategies adopted by D2C fashion brands. High investment in platform-based advertising, particularly on Meta owned platforms, increases brand visibility and ensures repeated exposure among target audience segments. Peer based word of mouth further reinforces awareness by validating brands encountered online through social or conversational contexts.

While these channels are effective in driving initial awareness, the nature of discovery through paid and algorithmic exposure also shapes the context in which brands are first perceived. The extent to which such exposure translates into positive or negative impressions depends on how messaging, tone, and perceived authenticity are interpreted, which is examined in subsequent sections of the analysis.

Overall, the findings suggest that brand discovery among Gen Z is predominantly platform led and exposure driven, making early attention cues and presentation critical in determining whether brands move beyond awareness into deeper consideration.

Question 7: What made you notice or remember these brands initially?

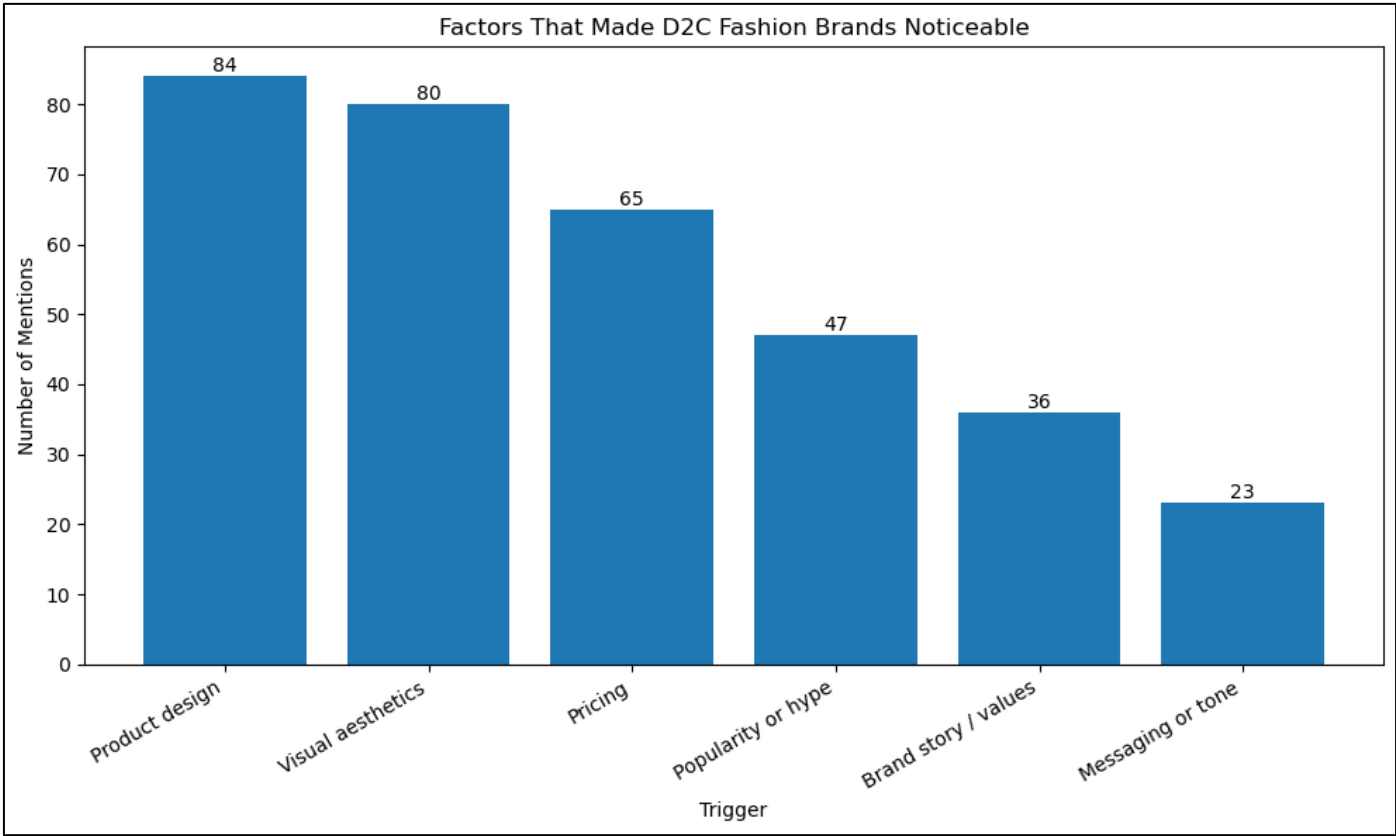


Figure 7

Initial Attention and Recall Triggers

The distribution of responses indicates that visual aesthetics and product design are the most influential factors in making Indian D2C fashion brands noticeable and memorable among Gen Z consumers. Pricing emerges as the next most frequently selected trigger, while popularity or hype, brand story or values, and messaging tone receive comparatively fewer mentions at the initial attention stage.

A closer examination of the response order reveals a consistent sequencing pattern. Out of 112 respondents, a substantial majority 80 to be exact selected visual aesthetics as their first trigger, followed by product design as the second. The third selection varied across respondents but was most commonly associated with pricing. This ordering suggests that Gen Z consumers initially respond to immediately visible and sensory cues before evaluating functional or Financial considerations.

Visual aesthetics appear to function as the primary attention hook, determining whether a brand is noticed at all. Product design then reinforces this interest by shaping perceptions of style relevance and usability. Pricing acts as a subsequent evaluative filter, influencing whether the initial interest generated by visuals and design is sustained or discontinued.

The comparatively lower emphasis on brand story, values, and messaging tone at this stage indicates that early brand recall is driven more by what is seen than by what is communicated verbally. For Gen Z consumers, brand meaning and narrative do not precede product evaluation. Instead, the product and its visual presentation serve as the primary signals through which brands earn consideration in the early stages of the decision-making process.

This pattern helps explain the effectiveness of visually driven discovery channels and sets the stage for examining how these initial cues translate into overall first impressions of D2C fashion brands, which is explored in the next question.

Question 8: On first impression, how appealing do most D2C fashion brands feel to you?

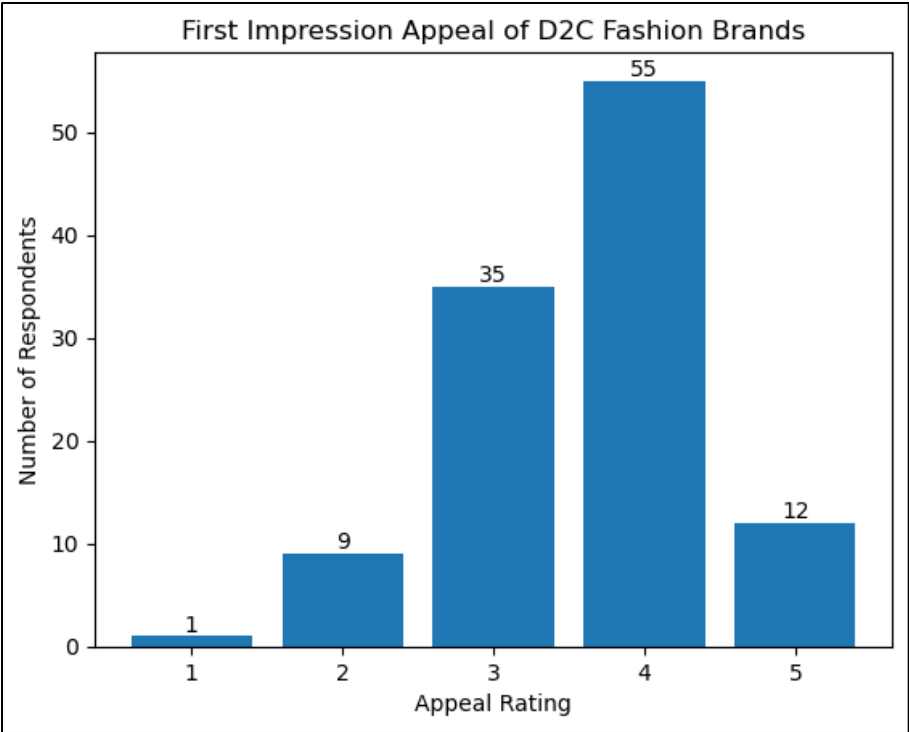


Figure 8

First Impression Appeal of D2C Fashion Brands

The distribution of responses indicates that most Gen Z consumers perceive Indian D2C fashion brands as moderately to highly appealing at the first impression stage. The majority of respondents rated overall appeal at level 4, followed by a substantial share selecting level 3. Very few respondents reported extremely low appeal, while a smaller but notable segment rated brands as highly appealing at level 5.

This pattern suggests that D2C fashion brands are generally successful in creating favourable initial impressions among Gen Z consumers. The clustering of responses around the mid to upper range indicates that visual presentation, product design, and pricing cues are effective in capturing attention and generating initial interest. At the same time, the relatively limited number of maximum appeal ratings suggests that while brands perform well at attracting attention, fewer achieve a strong or distinctive impact at first exposure.

The presence of moderate appeal ratings highlights an important nuance. Initial impressions are positive but not overwhelmingly compelling, implying that first contact alone may be insufficient to secure deeper engagement. This reinforces the idea that while discovery and attention triggers draw Gen Z consumers in, subsequent brand messaging and experience play a critical role in shaping whether early interest develops into trust and purchase intent.

Section 2 Summary

The analysis of brand awareness and discovery highlights how Gen Z consumers encounter and form initial impressions of Indian D2C fashion brands within a predominantly digital environment. Brand recall is concentrated around a limited set of D2C players, indicating that top of mind awareness is unevenly distributed, with only a few brands achieving strong cognitive visibility while many others remain peripheral.

Discovery is driven primarily by social media platforms, supported by online advertising and peer-based word of mouth. This pattern reflects a discovery process shaped by continuous digital exposure rather than intentional brand search. Within this context, initial attention is captured through visual aesthetics and product design, which function as the primary entry points into brand consideration. Pricing then acts as an early evaluative filter that determines whether initial interest is sustained.

Although these factors contribute to generally favourable first impressions, the overall appeal of D2C fashion brands tends to cluster at moderate to high levels rather than at the highest level of appeal. This suggests that while brands are effective at attracting attention and generating interest, first impressions alone are not sufficiently strong to secure commitment or loyalty.

Taken together, the findings indicate that brand awareness and discovery serve as necessary but insufficient stages in the Gen Z decision making journey. With consumers successfully drawn into awareness through visual and platform led exposure, the next stage of analysis examines how brand messaging, communication style, and perceived authenticity shape consumer perception beyond first impressions.

SECTION 3: BRAND MESSAGING AND PERCEPTION

After examining how Gen Z consumers become aware of and form initial impressions of Indian D2C fashion brands, the analysis now moves to how these brands communicate once attention has been captured. While discovery and visual appeal draw consumers in, it is brand messaging and communication style that shape how these early impressions are interpreted, validated, or questioned.

This section focuses on how Gen Z perceives the tone, style, and intent of D2C fashion brand communication across digital platforms. The questions explore whether brand messaging is viewed as relatable, trend driven, honest, or overly promotional, and whether communicated claims align with actual product or service experience. The section also examines perceptions of exaggeration, the platforms that most strongly influence brand perception, and whether Gen Z consumers feel brands are engaging in dialogue or delivering one-sided communication.

Understanding these dimensions is critical, as messaging acts as the bridge between initial awareness and deeper evaluation. It is at this stage that perceptions of authenticity begin to form or erode, shaping trust, scepticisms, and willingness to engage further. The findings in this section therefore lay the groundwork for analysing trust formation and decision-making behaviour in subsequent sections.

Question 9: How would you describe the general communication style of D2C fashion brands today

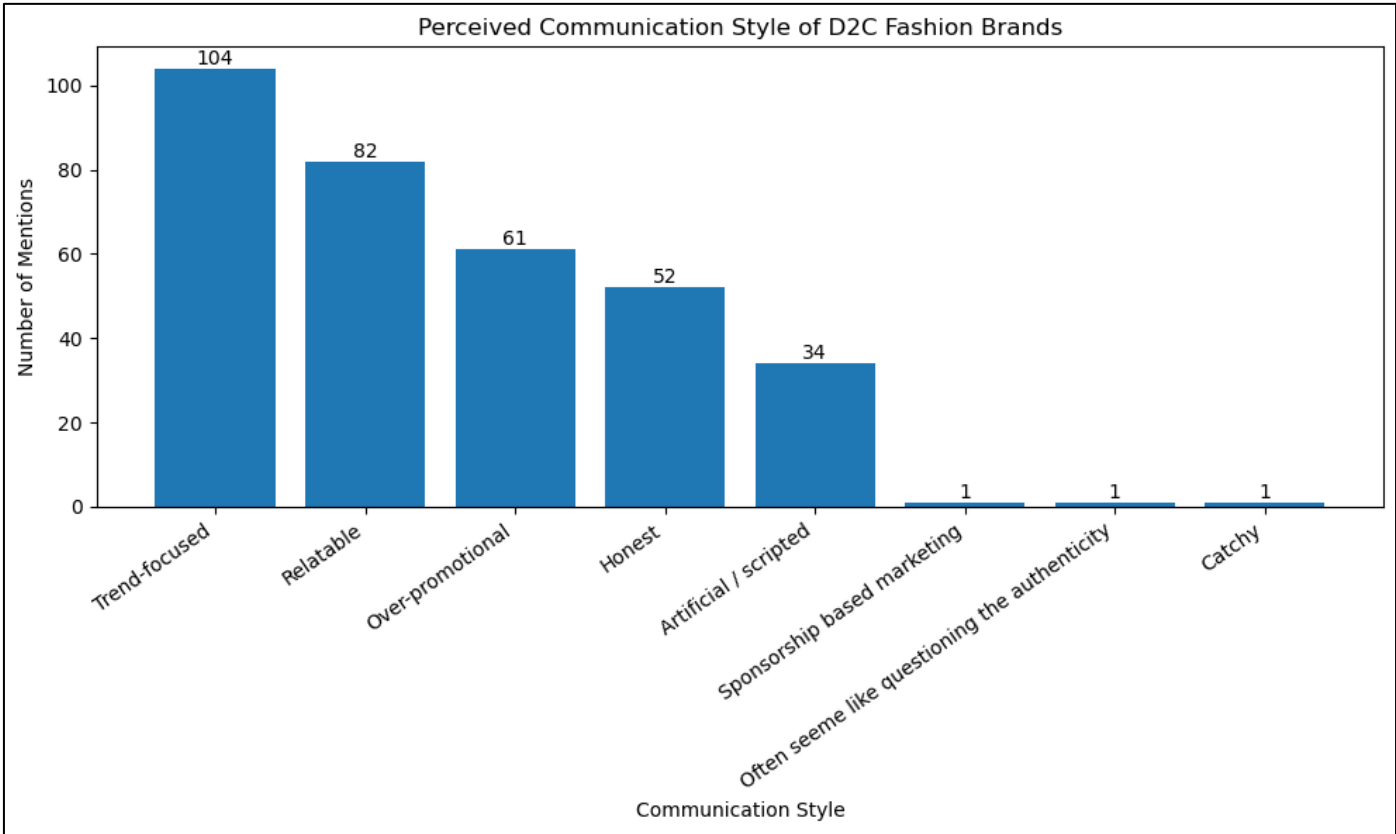


Figure 9

Perceived Communication Style of D2C Fashion Brands

The findings indicate that Gen Z consumers most commonly perceive Indian D2C fashion brand communication as trend focused and relatable. These attributes suggest that brands are actively attempting to align their messaging with youth culture, contemporary trends, and informal digital language. Honesty is also present as a perceived trait, though less prominently than trend orientation and relatability.

At the same time, a significant number of respondents associate D2C brand communication with over promotional and artificial or scripted qualities. This indicates that while messaging initially appears engaging and relevant, it often carries elements that reduce perceived credibility. The coexistence of positive descriptors with critical ones reflects a mixed reception rather than clear approval or rejection.

The order in which respondents selected options reinforces this pattern. Many respondents first identified communication as relatable or trend focused, but subsequently selected artificial or over promotional. This sequencing suggests that initial engagement with brand messaging is often positive, but sustained exposure leads to doubt regarding authenticity and intent.

Overall, the findings suggest that D2C fashion brand communication succeeds in capturing attention but operates within a fragile perception space, where efforts to appear relatable and trend aware are closely scrutinized by Gen Z consumers. This perception sets the stage for evaluating whether brand messaging aligns with actual product and service experience, which is examined next.

Question 10: To what extent does brand messaging match the actual product or service experience?

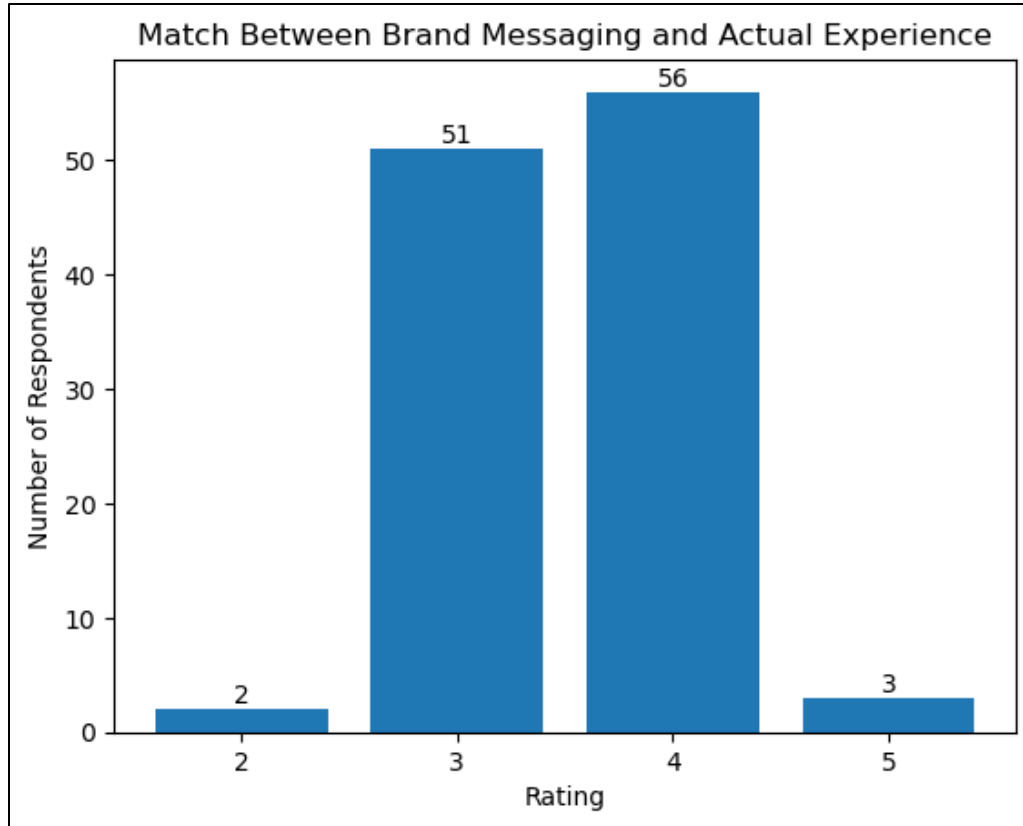


Figure 10

Match Between Brand Messaging and Actual Experience

The response distribution shows that most Gen Z consumers perceive a moderate to strong alignment between brand messaging and actual product or service experience in the Indian D2C fashion sector. The highest concentration of responses falls at rating 4, followed by rating 3, indicating that expectations created by brand communication are generally met and, in some cases, slightly exceeded.

Extreme dissatisfaction is minimal, and very few respondents report a complete mismatch between promise and delivery. This suggests that while scepticisms may exist at the messaging stage, the post purchase experience rarely results in outright disappointment. For most respondents, the perceived value appears broadly appropriate for the price paid.

The limited occurrence of the highest rating indicates that experiences are satisfactory but not consistently exceptional. One contributing factor may be the expectation inflation created by frequent influencer exposure and high intensity digital advertising, which can elevate perceived standards before purchase. Additionally, given that a large proportion of respondents are students with relatively constrained spending power, value

assessment is likely more cautious. In such cases, even well delivered products may be evaluated against heightened expectations rather than absolute quality benchmarks. For example, premium positioned D2C footwear brands with uniform pricing structures may meet functional expectations without being perceived as outstanding relative to cost.

Overall, the findings suggest that **the authenticity gap** at this stage is **not driven by severe delivery failure**, but by a narrow margin between promise and perceived value, where experiences feel fair rather than distinctly superior.

Question 11: How often do you feel D2C brands exaggerate or overpromise in their marketing

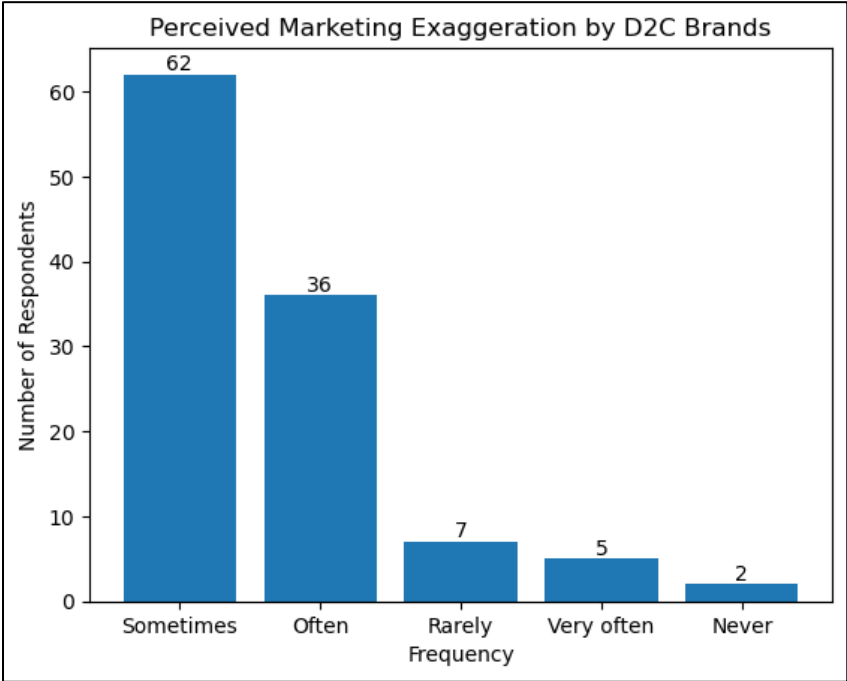


Figure 11

Perceived Marketing Exaggeration by D2C Brands

The findings indicate that Gen Z consumers perceive marketing exaggeration as a recurring but situational element of Indian D2C fashion brand communication. Most respondents selected “sometimes,” followed by “often,” suggesting that exaggeration is neither exceptional nor constant, but embedded within routine brand messaging. Very few respondents perceive exaggeration as either extreme or entirely absent.

This pattern indicates that Gen Z consumers approach D2C marketing with measured scepticisms rather than outright distrust. Promotional claims are not dismissed immediately, but they are interpreted with caution, particularly when messaging appears repetitive, heightened, or overly polished. Exaggeration at this stage does not function as a direct rejection trigger, but it begins to shape how credibility is assessed across subsequent interactions.

Importantly, this perception suggests that early signs of inauthenticity begin to emerge through how marketing messages are constructed and received, rather than through direct experience failure. Repeated exposure to elevated claims appears to contribute to a gradual recalibration of expectations, forming a background layer of doubt that influences later judgments around honesty, trust, and alignment between promise and behaviour.

This positions marketing exaggeration as an early indicator within the broader authenticity evaluation process, the implications of which are examined more directly in the following sections.

Q12. Which platform influences your perception of a D2C fashion brand the most?

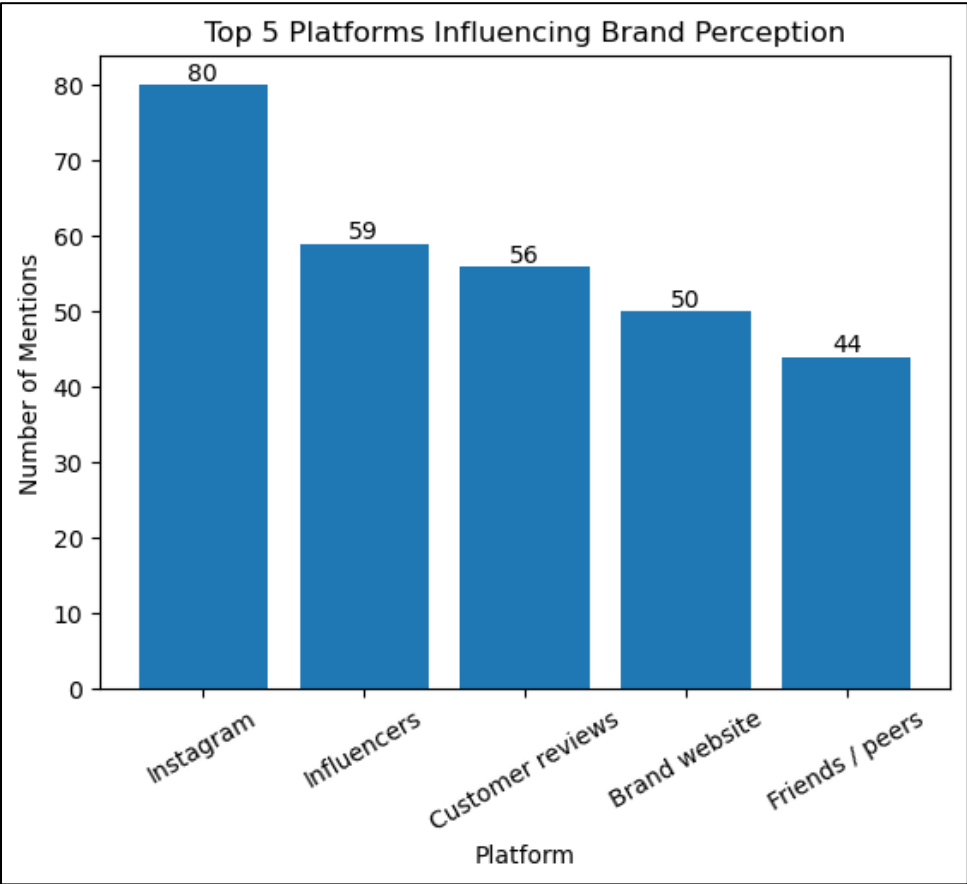


Figure 12

Platforms Influencing Brand Perception

The findings indicate that Instagram is the most influential platform shaping Gen Z perceptions of Indian D2C fashion brands, followed by influencers and customer reviews. Brand websites and friends or peers play a secondary role, suggesting that perception formation is driven primarily by platform mediated exposure rather than brand owned or interpersonal channels.

This pattern closely mirrors the discovery pathways identified earlier in Section 2, where social media platforms, particularly Instagram, emerged as the dominant channel for brand discovery and initial attention. The consistency between discovery and perception channels indicates that for Gen Z, the same platforms that introduce brands also continue to frame how those brands are evaluated over time.

The prominence of Instagram reinforces the role of algorithm driven content, paid advertising, and creator led narratives in shaping brand meaning. Influencers and customer reviews further extend this perception layer, blending promotional content with social validation. As a result, brand perception is formed within a high exposure, high repetition environment, where messaging is continuously encountered rather than deliberately sought.

Within this context, marketing intensity and presentation style take on heightened importance. When perception is shaped largely through promotional and algorithmically amplified channels, consumers become more sensitive to tone, exaggeration, and repetition. This helps explain why scepticisms and early signals of perceived inauthenticity begin to surface at the messaging stage, as observed in the preceding questions.

Overall, the findings suggest that Gen Z brand perception is platform anchored rather than brand anchored. Instagram functions not only as a discovery channel, but as a persistent lens through which brand communication, credibility, and intent are interpreted, setting the conditions under which authenticity is continuously evaluated.

Question 13: Do you feel D2C brands are mostly “talking with you” or “talking at you”?

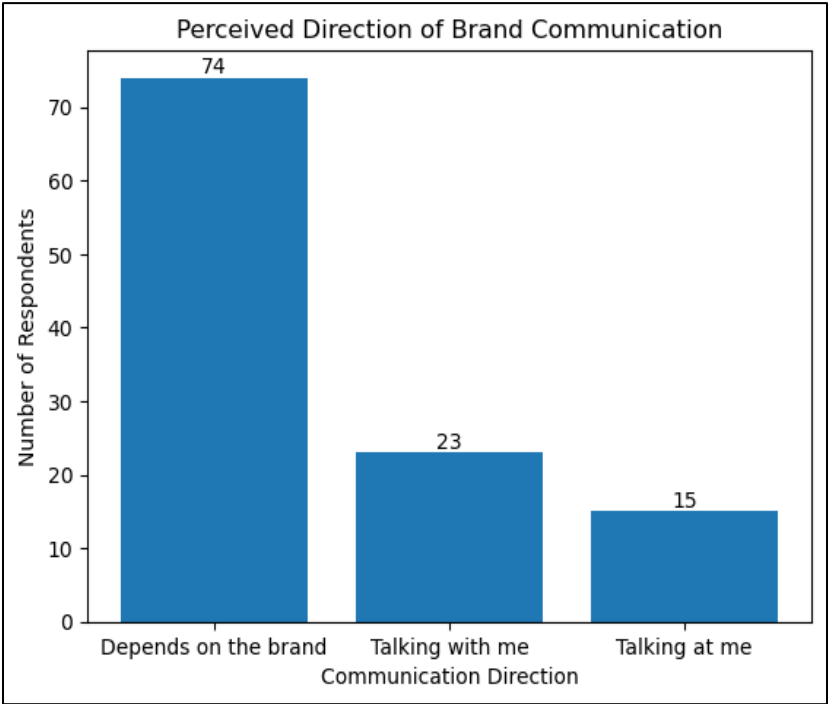


Figure 13

Perceived Direction of Brand Communication

The findings indicate that most Gen Z consumers do not perceive a single dominant communication approach across Indian D2C fashion brands. The majority of respondents selected “depends on the brand,” suggesting that communication quality and intent are evaluated at an individual brand level rather than assumed uniformly across the category.

A smaller but meaningful proportion of respondents feel that brands are talking with them, indicating the presence of two-way engagement and conversational communication in some cases. However, a notable segment also perceives brand communication as talking at them, reflecting experiences where messaging feels one sided, sales driven, or broadcast oriented rather than interactive.

This distribution suggests that Gen Z consumers are highly sensitive to how communication is delivered, not only to what is communicated. Brand messaging that appears personalized, responsive, or context aware is more likely to be perceived as dialogue, while repetitive or heavily promotional communication contributes to feelings of being spoken at.

Importantly, the dominance of the “depends on the brand” response indicates that Gen Z does not reject D2C brand communication outright. Instead, consumers actively differentiate between brands that demonstrate genuine engagement and those that rely on push-based messaging. This evaluative stance reinforces the idea that authenticity perception is formed through accumulated interactions rather than isolated messages.

These findings conclude the messaging and perception stage of the analysis and provide a direct transition to the next section, which examines how these perceptions influence trust formation, disengagement, and decision-making behaviour.

Section 3 Summary

The analysis of brand messaging and perception shows that Gen Z consumers engage actively with Indian D2C fashion brand communication, but do so with increasing evaluative caution. While brands are commonly perceived as trend focused and relatable, these positive attributes frequently coexist with perceptions of over promotion and artificial or scripted communication. This indicates that brand messaging succeeds in capturing attention, yet often operates within a narrow credibility window.

Across the section, a consistent pattern emerges. Initial engagement with brand communication is generally favourable, but sustained exposure introduces scepticisms, especially when messaging appears repetitive, overly polished, or heavily promotional. Although brand messaging is perceived to align reasonably well with actual product and service experience, the experience is more often described as satisfactory rather than exceptional. Expectations are broadly met, but rarely exceeded, reinforcing a cautious and measured trust posture.

Platform influence plays a central role in shaping these perceptions. With Instagram and influencer led content acting as the primary lenses through which brands are evaluated, Gen Z consumers encounter messaging in high frequency, algorithm driven environments. Within such contexts, sensitivity to tone, exaggeration, and perceived intent increases. As a result, early signs of perceived inauthenticity begin to surface at the messaging stage, even when post purchase experiences do not indicate major failure.

Perceptions of communication direction further reinforce this dynamic. Gen Z consumers do not evaluate D2C brand communication uniformly across the category. Instead, they actively differentiate between brands that appear conversational and responsive and those that rely on one sided, push based messaging. This suggests that authenticity is judged through accumulated interactions rather than isolated campaigns or claims.

Taken together, the findings indicate that inauthenticity does not emerge suddenly or solely from post purchase dissatisfaction. It develops gradually through repeated interpretation of brand messaging, platform behaviour, and communication style. For Gen Z consumers, authenticity becomes a continuous evaluative lens rather than a fixed judgment. These perceptions shape the conditions under which trust is later formed, weakened, or withdrawn, which is examined more directly in the next section focusing on trust formation, disengagement, and decision-making behaviour.

SECTION 4. TRUST FORMATION AND DECISION LOGIC

The previous section showed that concerns about inauthenticity tend to emerge early, particularly through brand messaging and platform led communication. These concerns do not usually lead to immediate rejection. Instead, they operate as a latent source of doubt that shapes how Gen Z consumers assess brands after initial awareness. This section extends the analysis by shifting attention from perception to outcome, focusing on how such doubts influence trust formation, purchase decisions, and eventual disengagement.

Within the D2C fashion context, trust plays a foundational role because consumers are expected to commit to purchases without direct physical evaluation of product quality, fit, or overall experience. Among Gen Z consumers, trust is rarely derived from brand size or market presence. It is formed through signals of honesty, reliance on peer-based validation, and alignment between what brands promise and what consumers experience. Decision logic therefore reflects cumulative brand behaviour across multiple interactions rather than the impact of isolated campaigns or individual messages.

Accordingly, this section examines the factors that exert the strongest influence on purchase decisions, the sources respondents rely on when forming trust judgments, and the stages at which interest begins to weaken. It also considers the perceived importance of authenticity as a decision criterion, the extent to which trust erosion follows message experience mismatches, and prevailing attitudes toward influencer driven promotion.

Taken together, these dimensions clarify how early perceptions of inauthenticity progress into active trust evaluation and behavioural response. The findings presented here mark the point at which brand communication outcomes translate into acceptance, scepticisms, disengagement, or brand switching within the Gen Z consumer journey.

Question 14: Which factors most influence your purchase decision from a D2C fashion brand

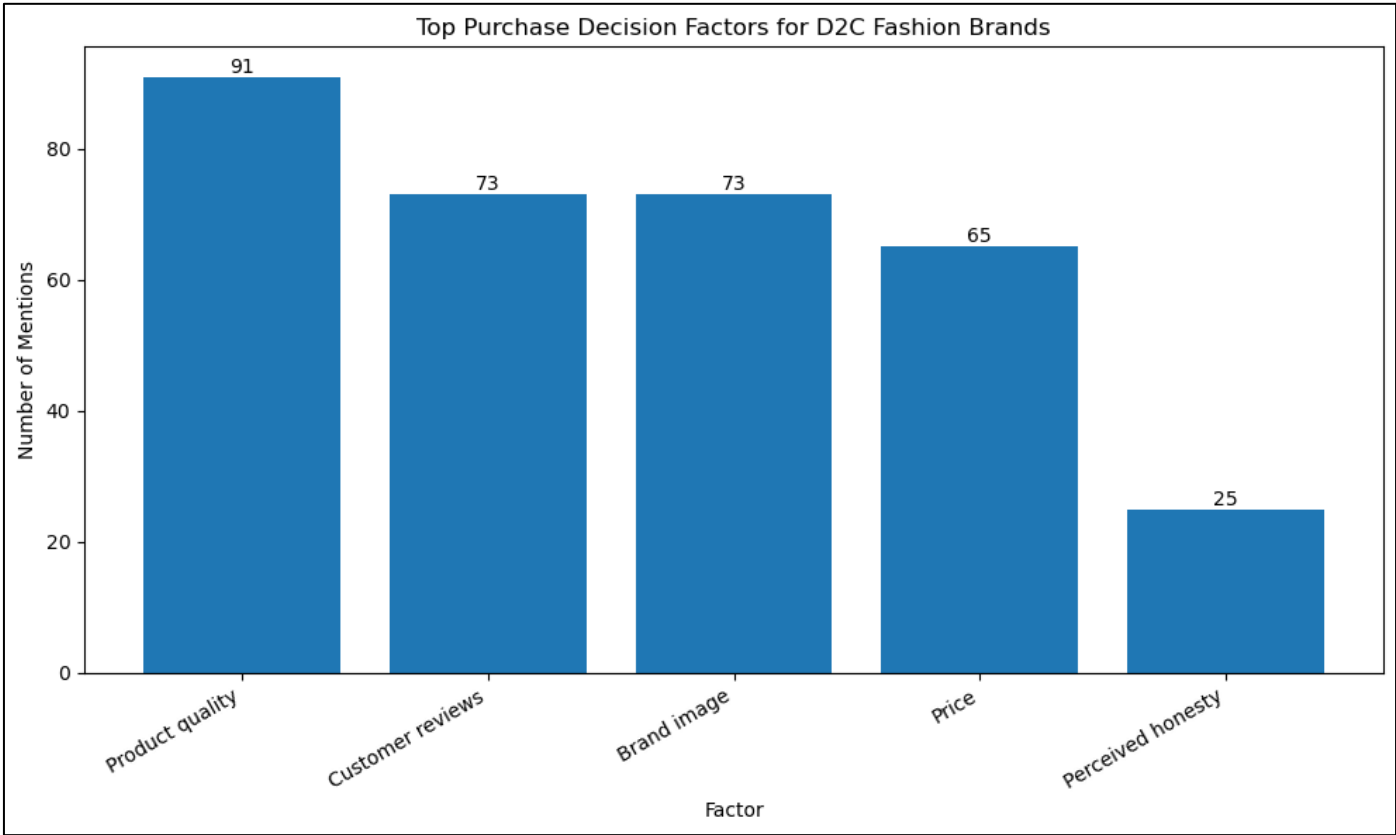


Figure 14

Factors Influencing Purchase Decisions

The results show that product quality is the most important factor influencing purchase decisions among Gen Z consumers in the Indian D2C fashion sector. This is followed by customer reviews and brand image, both of which play a substantial role in shaping purchase confidence. Price also emerges as an important consideration, while perceived honesty and influencer credibility are selected less frequently in comparison.

This distribution indicates that Gen Z consumers base their purchase decisions largely on factors that reduce uncertainty and perceived risk. Product quality represents the core expectation from a D2C brand, especially in an online setting where physical inspection is not possible. Customer reviews serve as an important source of reassurance, allowing consumers to rely on the experiences of others when evaluating fit, durability, and overall value. Brand image remains relevant, but it appears to function more as a supporting factor rather than a standalone reason for purchase.

The combination patterns further support this interpretation. Most respondents selected product quality and customer reviews together, often alongside price or brand image. This suggests that Gen Z consumers do not make decisions based on a single consideration. Instead, they evaluate multiple factors simultaneously, balancing expected product performance with social proof and value for money.

Influencer credibility and perceived honesty appear more often as secondary considerations rather than primary decision drivers. This indicates that while authenticity and trust related signals are important, they become influential mainly when supported by tangible evidence such as product quality and customer feedback. In practical terms, trust is built through consistency between what is promised, what is delivered, and what other consumers report.

Overall, the findings suggest that purchase decisions among Gen Z in the D2C fashion category are cautious and evaluation driven. Rather than impulse or persuasion alone, decisions are shaped by a deliberate assessment of quality, reviews, and value, reflecting a pragmatic approach to trust formation.

Question 15: What do you trust most while deciding to purchase from a D2C brand?

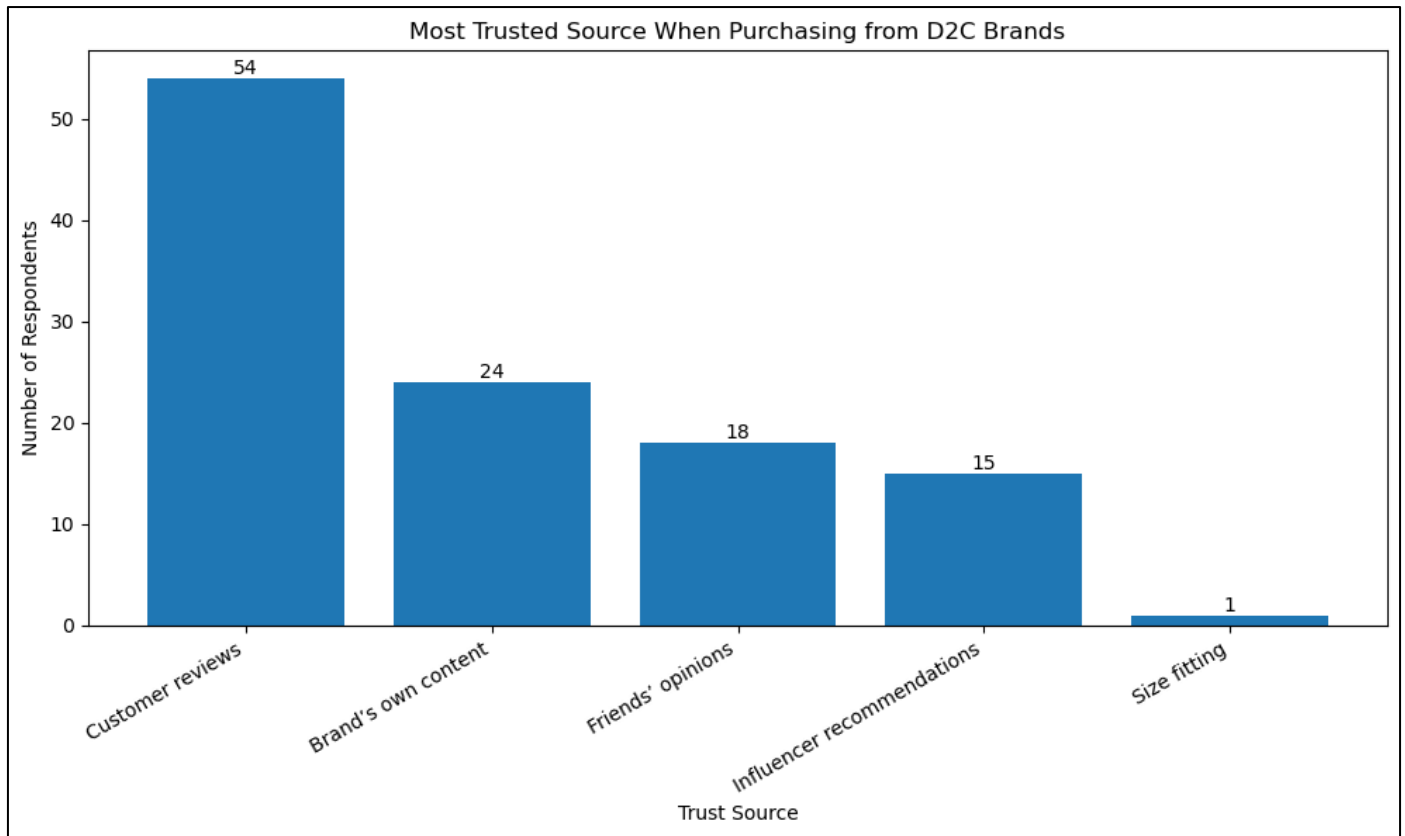


Figure 15

Most Trusted Source in Purchase Decisions

The findings show that customer reviews are the most trusted source when Gen Z consumers decide whether to purchase from an Indian D2C fashion brand. Brand owned content ranks a distant second, followed by friends' opinions. Influencer recommendations receive comparatively lower trust, and very few respondents rely on other sources.

This distribution highlights the central role of peer generated validation in the trust formation process. Customer reviews appear to function as a credibility checkpoint, allowing consumers to verify claims made through advertising, social media content, and influencer promotions. In an environment where brand messaging is widely recognized as curated and algorithm driven; reviews offer a form of perceived independence that reduces uncertainty.

The lower reliance on influencer recommendations is particularly notable given the prominence of influencer marketing in the D2C fashion space. While influencers remain visible and influential at the awareness stage, their role appears to weaken at the point of purchase, where consumers prioritize firsthand consumer experiences over promotional endorsements. Brand owned content, although still relevant, is approached with caution and is rarely treated as a sufficient basis for trust on its own.

These findings suggest that Gen Z consumers are highly aware of how digital platforms personalize content exposure. As a result, they actively seek out signals that they perceive as less mediated or commercially motivated. Trust is therefore transferred away from promotional voices and toward sources that appear experiential, unfiltered, and harder for brands to fully control.

This pattern reinforces the idea that authenticity evaluation intensifies as consumers move closer to purchase, setting the foundation for how dissatisfaction, disengagement, and critical expectations toward brand behaviour are later articulated.

Question 16: At which stage do you most commonly lose interest in a D2C fashion brand?

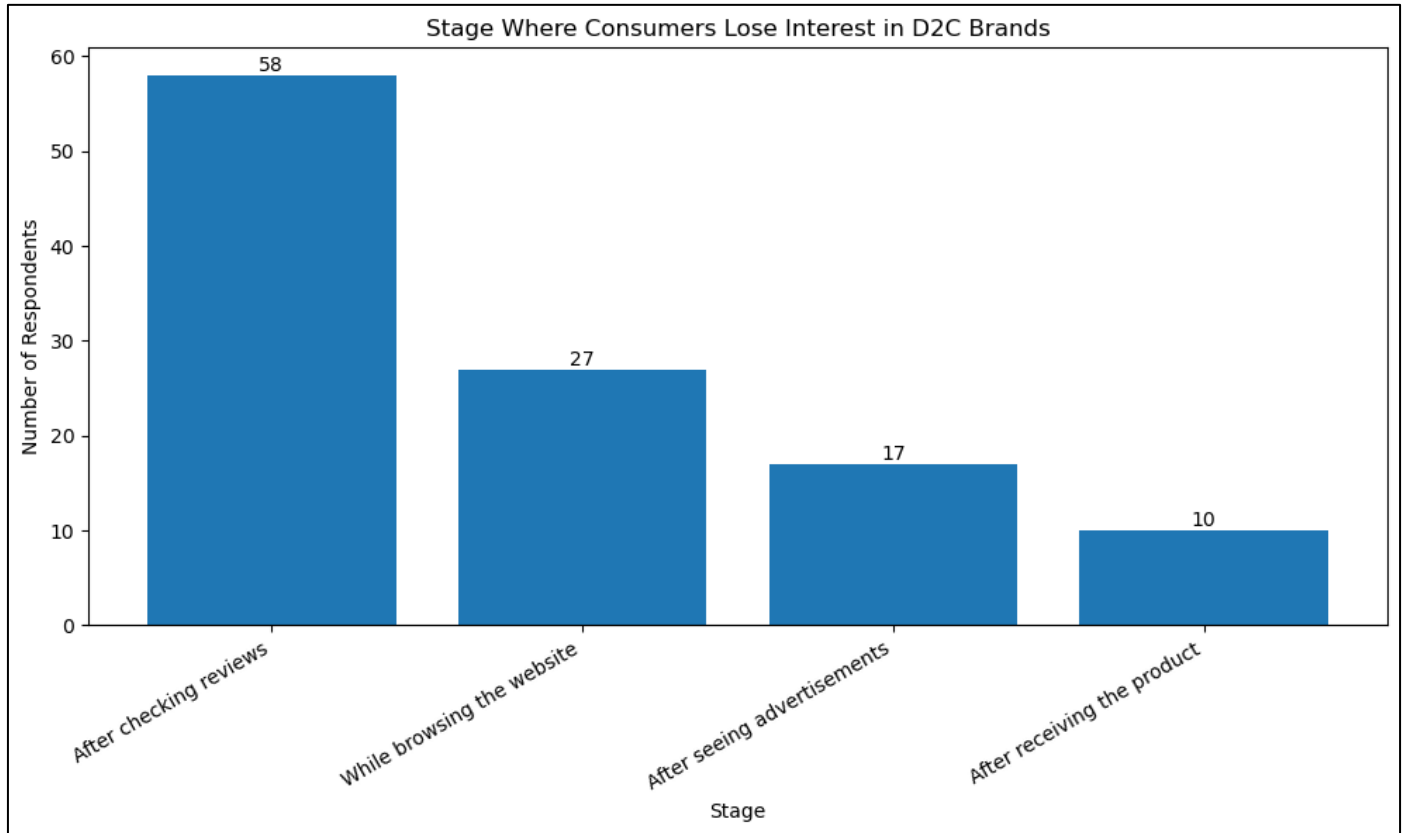


Figure 16

Stage at Which Consumers Lose Interest

The results show that Gen Z consumers most commonly lose interest in a D2C fashion brand after checking customer reviews. This is followed by disengagement while browsing the brand website. Fewer respondents report losing interest immediately after seeing advertisements, and only a small proportion disengage after receiving the product.

This pattern indicates that disengagement occurs primarily before purchase rather than after purchase. While advertisements and social media content succeed in generating awareness and initial interest, the review stage functions as a critical evaluation point where brand claims are assessed against the experiences of other consumers. When reviews do not support the expectations created by marketing communication, interest declines before a purchase decision is made.

When this finding is viewed alongside the results from Question 10, an important distinction becomes clear. Post purchase evaluations suggest that brand messaging generally aligns with actual product or service experience for those who complete a purchase. At the same time, Question 16 shows that many consumers

exit the decision process earlier, particularly after exposure to reviews. This indicates that dissatisfaction is not primarily expressed after purchase, but is filtered out before purchase through critical evaluation.

In this context, customer reviews operate as a screening mechanism that separates acceptable expectations from rejected ones. Consumers whose expectations remain consistent with external feedback proceed to purchase and report moderate satisfaction, while those who perceive a gap disengage earlier. As a result, the authenticity gap manifests less as widespread post purchase disappointment and more as pre purchase disengagement driven by expectation recalibration.

This finding reinforces the role of authenticity as a decision stage filter rather than a post experience reaction, setting the stage for examining how strongly authenticity influences purchase importance and trust withdrawal in the subsequent questions.

Question 17: How important is authenticity in your fashion purchase decisions



Figure 17

Importance of Authenticity in Fashion Purchase Decisions

The findings show that authenticity is a highly important factor in fashion purchase decisions for Gen Z consumers. The majority of respondents rated authenticity at levels 4 and 5, indicating strong importance, while a smaller group selected a moderate rating of 3. Very few respondents considered authenticity unimportant. This distribution confirms that authenticity is not a peripheral consideration, but a central evaluative criterion within the Gen Z decision making process.

When interpreted alongside earlier sections, the importance attached to authenticity becomes more meaningful. Section 2 showed that brand discovery and initial attention are largely driven by visual appeal and platform exposure, particularly through Instagram. Section 3 demonstrated that while messaging is often perceived as relatable and trend aligned, it also attracts scepticisms due to overpromotion, artificial tone, and repetitive exposure. Section 4 further revealed that trust formation depends heavily on customer reviews and product quality, with many consumers disengaging before purchase after evaluating external feedback.

In this context, authenticity functions as a stabilizing reference point. It reflects Gen Z's attempt to reconcile attractive brand presentation with credible signals of honesty, consistency, and alignment between promise and experience. Authenticity does not replace functional expectations such as quality or price, but it frames how these factors are interpreted. Brands that appear visually appealing yet inconsistent in messaging, reviews, or behaviour are filtered out before purchase, even if their products are not objectively poor.

The strong importance placed on authenticity also explains why disengagement occurs predominantly before purchase rather than after delivery. As earlier findings indicate, consumers who proceed to purchase generally report acceptable experiences. Those who disengage do so because authenticity doubts emerge during evaluation, not because of post purchase failure. Authenticity therefore operates as a decision gate rather than a post hoc judgment.

Overall, the findings confirm that for Gen Z consumers, authenticity is not an abstract brand ideal or moral preference. It is a practical decision criterion used to manage risk, assess credibility, and determine whether brand claims deserve trust. This centrality of authenticity provides the foundation for understanding why mismatches between image and reality lead to trust withdrawal and disengagement, which is examined directly in the next question.

Question 18: Have you ever stopped trusting or engaging with a brand due to a mismatch between image and reality

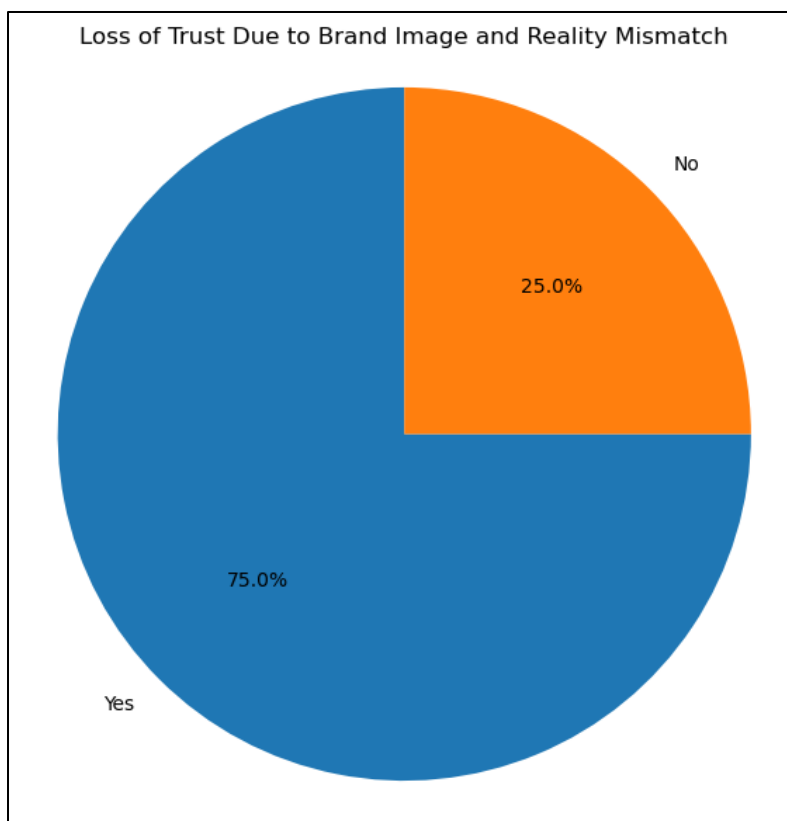


Figure 18

Loss of Trust Due to Brand Image and Reality Mismatch

The findings indicate that a substantial majority of respondents have stopped trusting or engaging with a D2C fashion brand due to a mismatch between brand image and actual experience. With three quarters of respondents answering in the affirmative, this result provides clear evidence that perceived inconsistency between projected messaging and reality leads to active trust withdrawal among Gen Z consumers.

This outcome confirms patterns observed in earlier sections. Sections 2 and 3 showed that brands succeed in attracting attention through strong visuals, trend aligned messaging, and platform driven exposure, particularly on Instagram. Section 4 demonstrated that trust is formed cautiously and filtered through customer reviews, perceived honesty, and cumulative signals rather than brand claims alone. Question 18 shows where this evaluative process culminates. When the gap between image and reality becomes evident, engagement does not merely weaken. It often stops.

Importantly, this trust loss is not limited to post purchase dissatisfaction. As earlier findings indicate, many consumers disengage during evaluation stages such as review checking or website browsing. The response to this question therefore reflects a broader definition of “reality,” which includes product quality, pricing fairness, delivery experience, customer support, and the credibility of marketing claims. A mismatch at any of these points contributes to perceived inauthenticity.

The fact that a quarter of respondents report not having experienced such trust loss suggests that disengagement is not inevitable. Some brands succeed in maintaining alignment between promise and performance. This reinforces the idea that authenticity is evaluated at the brand level rather than assumed across the category.

Overall, the findings from this question mark a critical transition in the analysis. Authenticity is no longer an abstract expectation or evaluative preference. It becomes a behavioural threshold. Once crossed, it results in withdrawal of trust and disengagement. This provides a direct link between perception, trust erosion, and consumer exit behaviour, which is further explored in the final question of this section.

Question 19: How do you feel about heavy influencer marketing by D2C fashion brands?

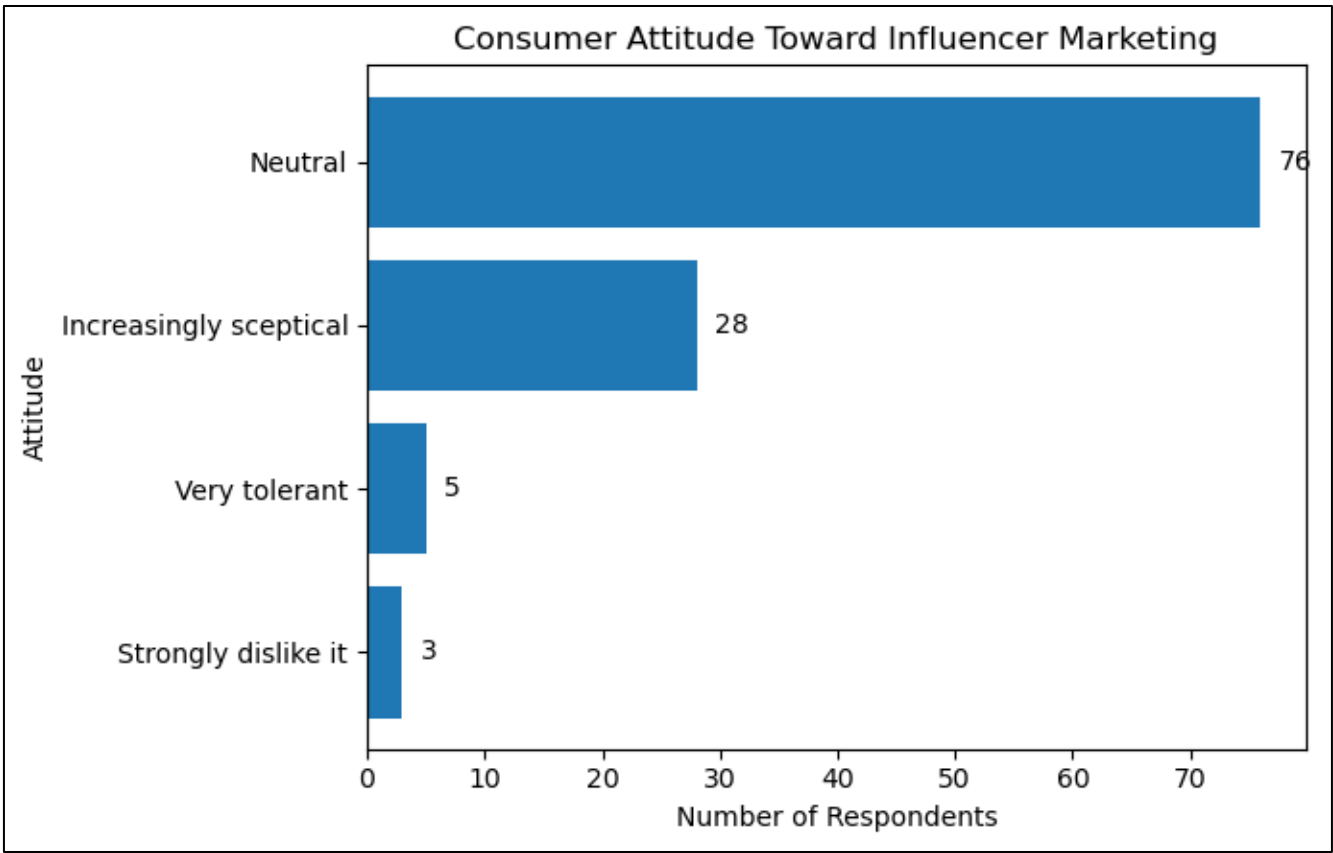


Figure 19

Consumer Attitude Toward Heavy Influencer Marketing

The findings indicate that Gen Z consumers do not display outright rejection of influencer marketing, but neither do they demonstrate strong acceptance. The largest proportion of respondents report a neutral attitude toward heavy influencer marketing, followed by a substantial segment that is increasingly sceptical. Very few respondents describe themselves as highly tolerant, and only a small minority report strong dislike.

This distribution suggests that influencer marketing has shifted from being a persuasive driver to a normalized background presence within the D2C fashion ecosystem. Neutrality in this context does not imply trust or endorsement. Instead, it reflects desensitization resulting from repeated exposure. Influencer content is no longer perceived as novel, distinctive, or inherently credible. It is expected, anticipated, and therefore subjected to closer scrutiny.

The presence of growing scepticism is particularly significant when viewed alongside earlier findings. In Sections 2 and 3, influencer content played a visible role in discovery and perception formation, yet trust at the decision stage was driven primarily by customer reviews rather than influencer recommendations. Question 19 reinforces this pattern by showing that while influencer marketing remains tolerated, its persuasive authority is weakening.

This attitude aligns with concerns expressed in later open-ended responses, where respondents explicitly question paid promotions, repetitive creator partnerships, and perceived lack of originality. Influencer overuse appears to function less as a trust builder and more as a signal that prompts evaluation and verification through independent sources such as reviews and peer feedback.

Overall, the findings suggest that influencer marketing is no longer a decisive credibility signal for Gen Z consumers. Instead, excessive or repetitive influencer use contributes to the broader perception environment in which authenticity is questioned. While not immediately triggering disengagement, it accelerates scepticism and reinforces the need for brands to substantiate claims through experience, transparency, and third-party validation rather than amplification alone.

Section 4 Summary.

The analysis shows that trust among Gen Z consumers in the Indian D2C fashion sector is formed cautiously and evaluated before purchase rather than after delivery. Purchase decisions are driven primarily by product quality, customer reviews, brand image, and price, with **customer reviews** acting as the most trusted validation source. **Influencer** credibility plays a **limited** role at the decision stage despite **high visibility** earlier in the journey.

Disengagement most commonly occurs after checking reviews or while browsing the brand website, indicating that authenticity concerns are filtered during evaluation rather than expressed as post purchase dissatisfaction. This finding aligns with earlier results showing moderate alignment between messaging and experience for those who proceed to purchase. Consumers who continue report acceptable outcomes, while those who perceive gaps disengage before buying.

Authenticity emerges as a central decision criterion, not as an abstract value but as a practical risk management tool. A large majority report having withdrawn trust due to mismatches between brand image and reality, confirming authenticity as a behavioural threshold. Attitudes toward influencer marketing remain largely neutral to sceptical, suggesting declining persuasive power and increasing scrutiny.

Overall, this section establishes that inauthenticity operates as a pre purchase filter. Trust is built through cumulative signals of consistency, peer validation, and delivery alignment, and when these signals fail, disengagement occurs early. This sets the foundation for examining how consumers explicitly define authenticity and articulate corrective expectations in the final section.

SECTION 5. CONSUMER INSIGHTS AND STRATEGIC FEEDBACK

The earlier sections examined how awareness, messaging, and trust evaluation shape Gen Z engagement with Indian D2C fashion brands. This final section moves from structured evaluation to explicit consumer voice. It focuses on how Gen Z consumers themselves define authenticity, identify inauthentic brand behaviour, and articulate reasons for continued support or disengagement.

The questions in this section capture open ended interpretations of authenticity alongside direct assessments of what brands get wrong in practice. They explore the specific behaviours, signals, and communication patterns that strengthen or weaken trust from the consumer perspective. This includes perceptions of influencer use, marketing credibility, product delivery, and value alignment, as well as the triggers that lead consumers to stop buying from brands they once supported.

By centring consumer language and judgment, this section surfaces the practical meaning of authenticity as experienced by Gen Z rather than as defined by brands. The insights generated here translate earlier analytical findings into clear diagnostic signals and corrective expectations. This section therefore provides the basis for synthesizing conclusions and developing grounded recommendations in the final chapter.

Question 20: In your own words, what does an authentic fashion brand mean to you?

Analysis of the open-ended responses reveals a high level of consistency in how Gen Z consumers define authenticity in the fashion context. Across responses, authenticity is not described as a branding aesthetic or narrative device, but as a condition of alignment between what a brand claims and what it delivers in practice.

The most dominant theme is **promise–delivery alignment**. Respondents repeatedly define authentic brands as those that deliver exactly what is advertised, whether in terms of product quality, materials, fit, visuals, or timelines. Any deviation between marketing imagery and the received product is interpreted as inauthentic, regardless of intent. Authenticity, in this sense, is treated as a testable outcome rather than a subjective feeling.

A second strong theme is **honesty and transparency**. Many respondents emphasize truthfulness in advertising, clarity about product attributes, and openness in addressing issues highlighted through reviews. Transparency is valued not as a moral stance alone, but as a mechanism that enables trust and reduces uncertainty in online purchasing.

The third recurring theme is **consistency over trend chasing**. Respondents frequently contrast authenticity with brands that aggressively follow short lived trends. Authentic brands are described as those with a clear identity, original style, and stable creative direction, even if this means slower trend adoption. This indicates that Gen Z associates' authenticity with coherence and long-term intent rather than rapid responsiveness.

A smaller but notable set of responses link authenticity to **values and purpose**, including founder intent, ethical behaviours, and long-term relationship building. However, these value-based elements are consistently framed as credible only when supported by product quality and consistent execution. Values without delivery are not considered authentic.

Overall, Gen Z consumers define authenticity in operational rather than symbolic terms. An authentic fashion brand is expected to be honest in its claims, consistent in its behaviours, transparent in its communication, and reliable in its delivery. Authenticity is therefore experienced as a lived brand reality, not as a storytelling exercise. This definition provides the foundation for understanding why certain brand behaviours are later labelled as fake or inauthentic, which is examined in the next question.

Question 21: What makes a D2C fashion brand feel inauthentic or fake

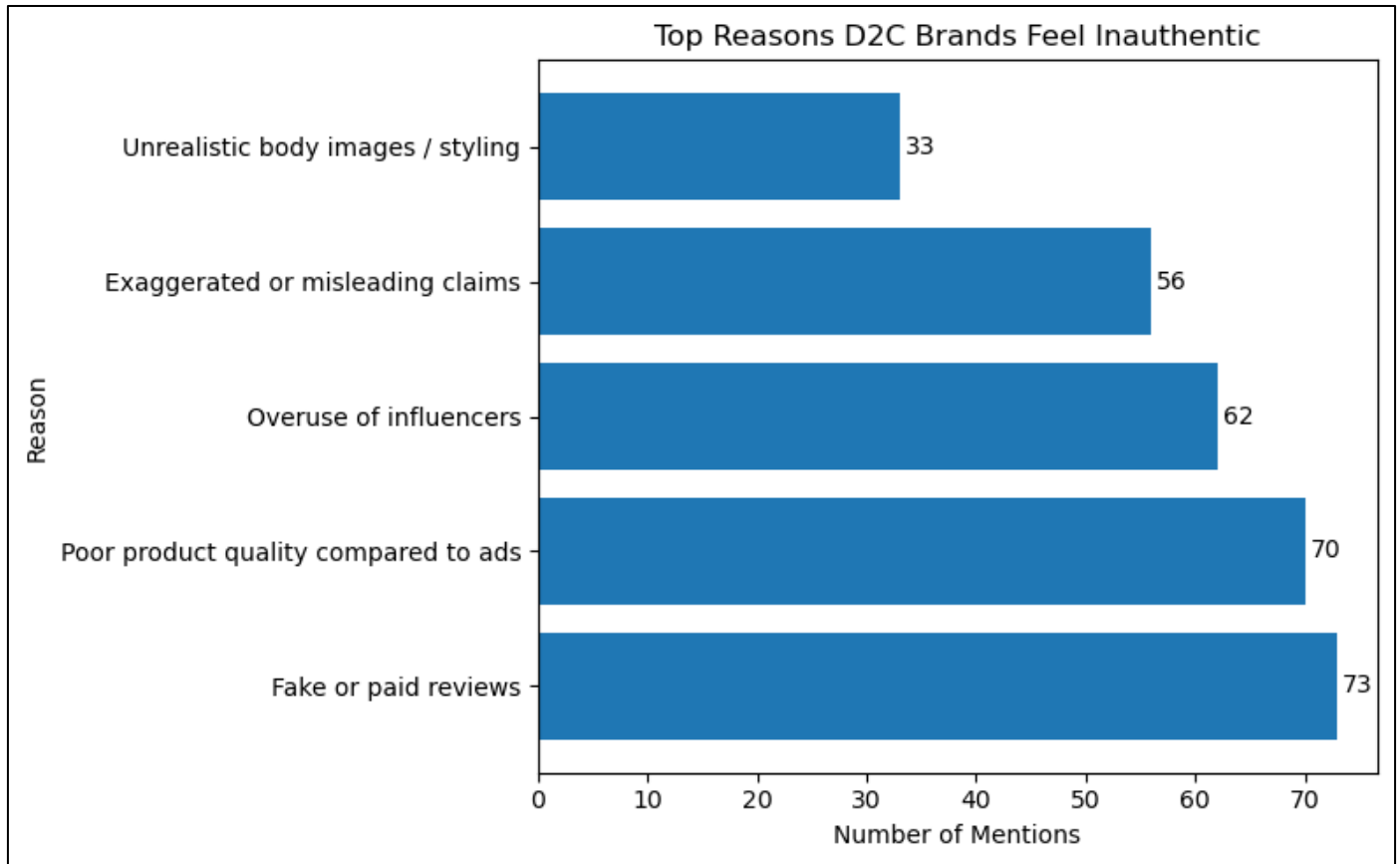


Figure 20

Factors That Make D2C Fashion Brands Feel Inauthentic

When interpreted alongside the definition of authenticity established in Question 20, the findings from this question reveal a clear mirror relationship between expectation and violation. Gen Z respondents defined authenticity primarily in terms of honesty, consistency, and promise–delivery alignment. The reasons identified here as making brands feel inauthentic correspond directly to the breakdown of those same conditions.

The most frequently cited factor, fake or paid reviews, directly contradicts the importance placed on transparency and peer validation. In earlier sections, customer reviews emerged as the most trusted input in purchase decisions. When reviews are perceived as manipulated, the credibility mechanism Gen Z relies on collapses, triggering immediate distrust.

Poor product quality compared to advertisements and exaggerated or misleading claims reflect a failure of promise–delivery alignment, which was the central theme in how respondents defined authenticity. These findings reinforce that inauthenticity is not driven by branding style alone, but by gaps between communicated expectations and lived outcomes.

Overuse of influencers aligns with earlier observations from Sections 3 and 4, where influencer marketing was tolerated but increasingly questioned. While influencers contribute to awareness, their excessive or repetitive use is interpreted as artificial amplification rather than genuine endorsement, weakening trust rather than strengthening it.

Lower but still notable mentions of unrealistic body images and styling further indicate sensitivity to visual misrepresentation. This connects back to Section 2, where visuals and aesthetics were shown to be powerful attention triggers. When these visuals are later perceived as misleading, they become a source of inauthenticity rather than appeal.

Taken together, the findings show that inauthenticity is not an abstract label applied loosely by Gen Z consumers. It is the direct result of identifiable violations of the principles they associate with authentic brands. What Gen Z describes as authentic in Question 20 is precisely what they penalize when absent in Question 21. This reinforces the idea that authenticity operates as a practical standard against which brand behaviours is continuously evaluated, rather than as a symbolic brand attribute.

Question 22: Think about your most recent D2C fashion purchase. What finally convinced you to buy

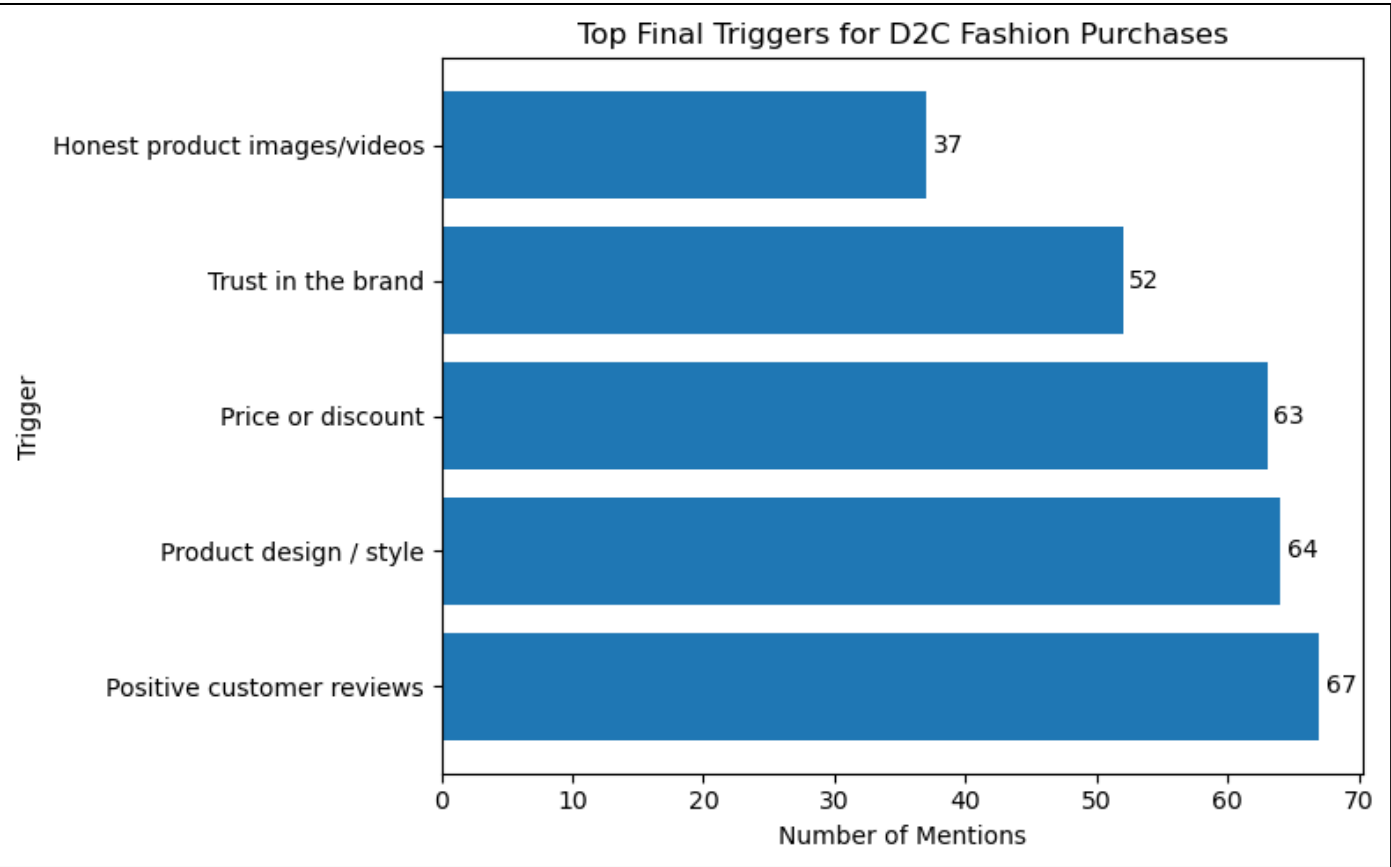


Figure 21

Final Triggers That Led to Purchase

The findings show that the final decision to purchase from a D2C fashion brand is driven primarily by positive customer reviews, followed closely by product design or style and price or discount. Trust in the brand and honest product images or videos also play an important supporting role, while influencer promotion appears far less central at the point of conversion.

This pattern reinforces a key theme running through the earlier sections. While discovery and awareness are heavily shaped by social media exposure and influencer activity, the final purchase decision is anchored in credibility and risk reduction. Positive customer reviews emerge as the strongest conversion trigger because they allow consumers to validate brand claims against real user experience. This aligns directly with earlier findings where reviews acted as a critical filter for trust and a common stage of disengagement when expectations were not supported.

Product design or style remaining a strong trigger reflects the visual orientation identified in Section 2. However, its effectiveness at the purchase stage depends on confirmation from reviews and pricing logic rather than visual appeal alone. Price or discount also plays a major role, particularly given the student dominated sample with constrained discretionary income, reinforcing that value assessment remains central even when trust is present.

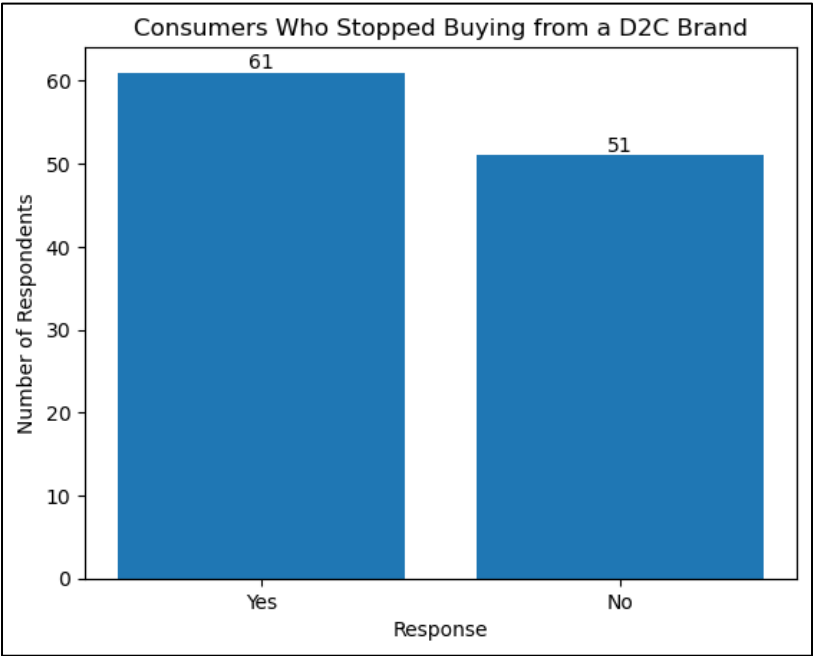
Trust in the brand and honest product images or videos function as reinforcing signals rather than standalone drivers. Their presence supports the decision once external validation and value expectations are satisfied. Influencer promotion, although visible across earlier stages, appears largely supplementary at this point, confirming its declining persuasive power during final evaluation.

Overall, the findings indicate that Gen Z purchase decisions are resolved through a convergence of authenticity related cues. Visual appeal draws attention, but independent validation, realistic representation, and value alignment ultimately determine conversion. This further confirms that authenticity operates as a practical decision mechanism rather than an abstract brand ideal, shaping not only disengagement but also the final moment of purchase commitment.

Question 23 and **Question 24** are treated as a linked sequence. Question 23 identifies prior disengagement from a D2C fashion brand, while Question 24 explores the underlying reasons for this disengagement among those respondents. Together, these questions allow the study to first establish the occurrence of brand abandonment and then examine its drivers within the relevant respondent group.

Question 23: Have you ever stopped buying from a D2C fashion brand you once liked?

Figure 22



Question 24: Have you ever stopped buying from a D2C fashion brand you once liked?

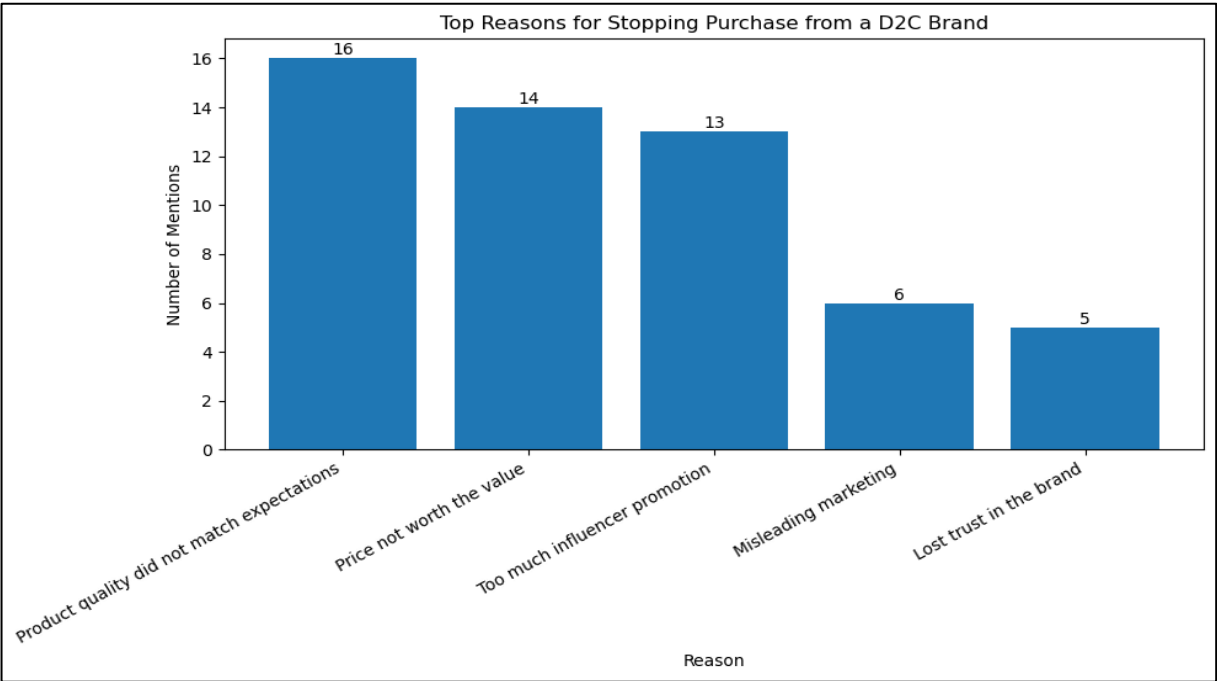


Figure 23

Question 23 and Question 24. Brand Disengagement and Reasons for Stopping Purchase

The findings from Questions 23 and 24 reveal that brand disengagement is a common and meaningful outcome within the Gen Z consumer journey in India's D2C fashion sector. A majority of respondents report having stopped buying from a D2C fashion brand they once liked, indicating that disengagement is not an isolated reaction to rare failures but a recurring behavioural response.

Among those who discontinued purchases, the most frequently cited reason is product quality not matching expectations, followed closely by price not being worth the perceived value. Excessive influencer promotion also emerges as a prominent reason for disengagement, while misleading marketing and explicit loss of trust, though less frequently selected, remain significant contributors. These reasons collectively point to a pattern of expectation failure rather than operational breakdown alone.

When interpreted alongside earlier findings, a critical distinction becomes evident. Section 3 showed that brand messaging is often perceived as appealing, trend focused, and visually strong, while Section 4 demonstrated that post purchase experiences are generally rated as acceptable rather than severely disappointing. Yet, despite this, disengagement remains high. This indicates that Gen Z consumers are not primarily reacting to poor products in absolute terms. Instead, they are reacting to a misalignment between what brands project and how value is ultimately evaluated.

The combined findings from Questions 23 and 24 provide direct evidence of an authenticity driven gap between brand perception and consumer decision making logic. D2C fashion brands frequently optimize communication to maximize attention, aspiration, and desirability through polished visuals, influencer amplification, and elevated claims. In contrast, Gen Z consumers approach purchase continuation through a verification-based logic that prioritizes consistency, peer validation, and justification of price through delivered value.

Product quality failing to meet expectations and price being perceived as unjustified signal that expectations are being inflated at the communication stage. Excessive influencer promotion further contributes to this gap by amplifying desirability without proportionately strengthening credibility. As a result, even when products are functionally adequate, they may still fail to satisfy the evaluative standards shaped by marketing narratives.

divergence confirms the presence of a structural authenticity gap. Brand perception is constructed through image led communication, while consumer decision making is governed by risk reduction and expectation calibration. When these two logics do not align, trust erosion does not manifest only as dissatisfaction. It manifests as withdrawal, avoidance, and brand switching.

Importantly, disengagement in this context is cumulative rather than impulsive. Consumers do not abandon brands solely due to one poor interaction. They disengage when repeated signals suggest that the brand's projected image is not consistently supported by product delivery, pricing logic, or behavioural integrity. In this sense, inauthentic marketing does not merely weaken brand image. It actively disrupts the consumer decision making process, leading to loss of loyalty even in the absence of severe product failure.

These findings mark a critical analytical point in the study. Authenticity is no longer an abstract expectation or a soft branding attribute. It functions as a threshold condition for retention. Once crossed, it results in disengagement and brand exit, reinforcing the central argument of this research regarding the authenticity gap in India's D2C fashion sector.

Question 25: What do you think most Indian D2C fashion brands get wrong about Gen Z?

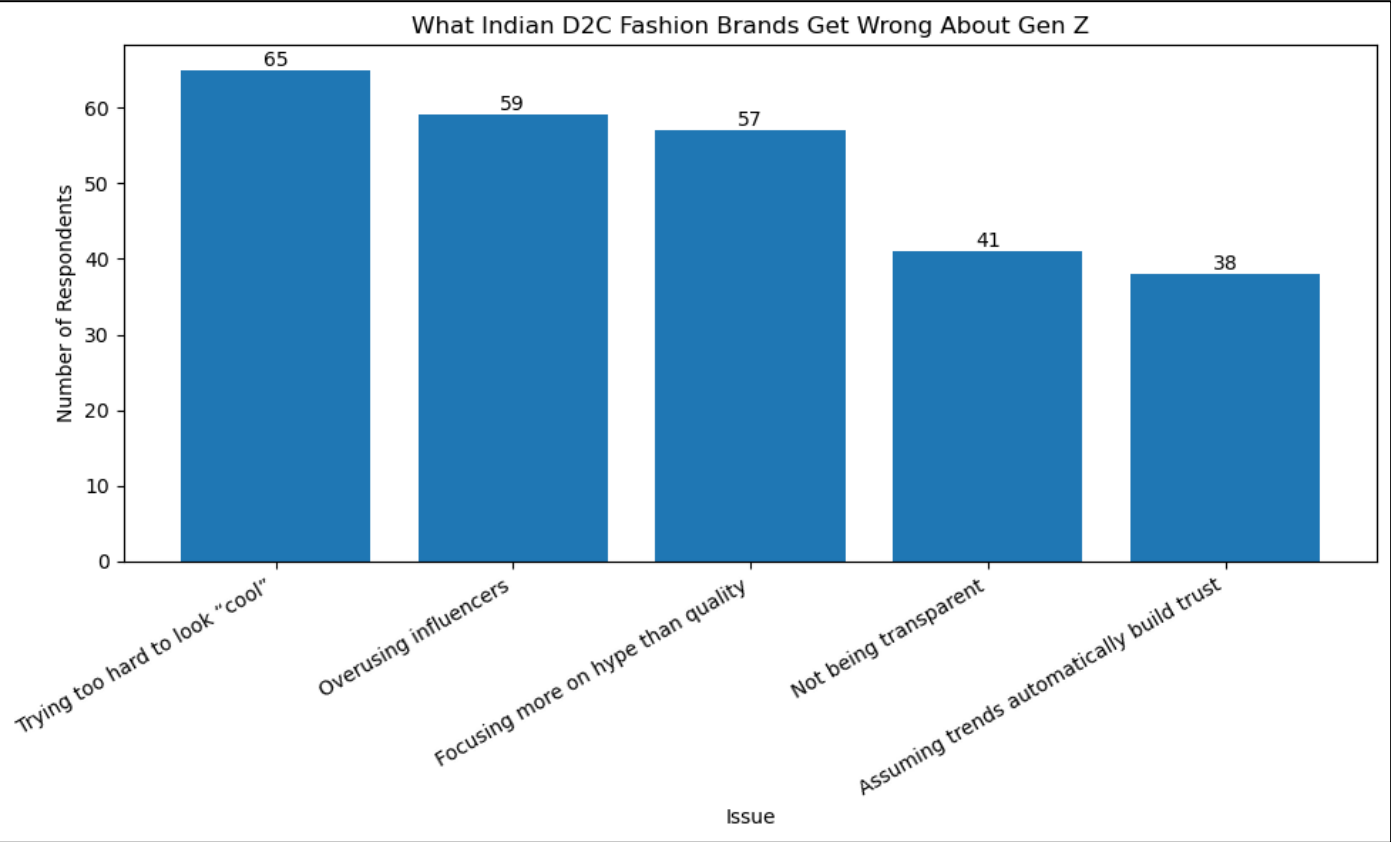


Figure 24

What Indian D2C Fashion Brands Get Wrong About Gen Z

The findings from Question 25 bring the authenticity gap into explicit focus by revealing how Gen Z interprets brand intent versus brand behaviours. The most frequently selected issue, “trying too hard to look cool,” indicates a clear rejection of performative branding. Gen Z consumers do not respond positively to forced cultural alignment, slang driven communication, or exaggerated attempts to appear trend relevant. Instead, such efforts are interpreted as inauthentic and disconnected from real product value.

Closely following this, overusing influencers and focusing more on hype than quality emerge as dominant criticisms. These results directly connect with earlier findings in Sections 3 and 4, where influencer marketing was shown to attract awareness but lose persuasive power at the decision stage. The data confirms that Gen Z does not equate visibility with credibility. When influencer presence replaces substance, it accelerates scepticisms rather than trust.

The perception that brands are not transparent and assume trends automatically build trust further reinforces this pattern. Gen Z consumers clearly distinguish between trend participation and trustworthiness. Trend alignment may generate short term attention, but trust is evaluated through consistency, clarity, and delivery. Brands that rely on trend velocity without reinforcing quality, honest representation, and responsive behaviours are perceived as misunderstanding Gen Z expectations.

When connected with Questions 23 and 24, these findings explain why disengagement occurs even among brands that achieve strong initial awareness. The same behaviours Gen Z identifies as misunderstandings, excessive hype, influencer saturation, and surface level coolness, also appear as reasons for stopping purchases and withdrawing trust. This confirms that the authenticity gap is not accidental. It is produced by strategic misalignment between how brands attempt to appeal and how Gen Z actually evaluates value and credibility.

Overall, Question 25 functions as a diagnostic mirror. It shows that Indian D2C fashion brands often optimize for attention-based metrics while Gen Z operates on a verification-based decision logic. The failure to recognize this difference leads to inflated expectations, credibility erosion, and eventual disengagement. This sets a direct foundation for the final question, which captures Gen Z's corrective advice on what brands should stop doing immediately.

Q26. If you were advising a D2C fashion brand, what is ONE thing they should stop doing immediately?

Responses to this open-ended question provide a clear and consistent corrective message from Gen Z consumers. The dominant recommendation is not about starting new activities, but about stopping specific behaviours that are perceived as damaging trust and long-term brand value.

The most frequently mentioned issue is misrepresentation. Respondents repeatedly highlight the need to stop using misleading product images, exaggerated visuals, and idealized models that do not reflect how products appear in reality. The mismatch between advertised appearance and actual delivery is viewed as a direct violation of trust rather than a minor marketing flaw. This reinforces earlier findings where image reality gaps triggered disengagement before and after purchase.

A second strong theme is the overreliance on influencers, paid collaborations, and performance marketing. Many respondents explicitly call out fake or paid reviews, excessive influencer use, and dependence on ads as signals of low credibility. Gen Z does not object to influencers in principle, but clearly rejects influencer driven validation when it replaces honest product proof. This aligns with prior sections showing that influencer visibility loses influence at the decision stage and accelerates scepticisms.

The third recurring concern relates to trend chasing. Respondents advise brands to stop copying viral trends, overusing Gen Z coded language, and pivoting identity too frequently. Trend obsession is perceived as a lack of brand character and creative confidence. In contrast, respondents value brands that focus on timeless products, consistent design language, and a clear point of view. Several responses emphasize quality over quantity, fewer better products rather than broad assortments driven by short term hype.

Finally, some responses point to a strategic imbalance between acquisition and retention. Overemphasis on paid growth, new customer acquisition, and rapid launches is seen as coming at the cost of product quality, customer experience, and long-term trust. This reinforces the broader finding that Gen Z evaluates brands over time rather than through isolated campaigns.

Taken together, Question 26 crystallizes the core issue identified throughout the analysis. Inauthentic marketing does not fail because it lacks reach or creativity. It fails because it conflicts with Gen Z's decision-making logic, which prioritizes honesty, consistency, and delivery over amplification. The advice to stop misleading visuals, influencer excess, and trend chasing serves as a direct blueprint for closing the gap between brand perception and consumer trust in India's D2C fashion sector.

Section 5 summary

This section records Gen Z's own language about authenticity and provides direct, actionable feedback for brands. Authenticity is defined operationally. Respondents expect alignment between marketing claims and delivered product attributes, clear transparency about materials and sourcing, and a consistent brand identity rather than rapid trend chasing.

Main drivers of perceived inauthenticity are fake or paid reviews, product quality that falls short of advertised images, exaggerated claims, and excessive influencer amplification. These violations map directly to the expectations set out by respondents. When peer validation is corrupted or visuals do not match reality, credibility collapses and consumers withdraw.

Purchase decisions resolve through independent verification. Positive customer reviews, product design, and price are the most frequent final triggers. Influencer promotion helps attract attention, but it rarely closes the sale without supporting evidence from reviews or honest product imagery.

Brand switching is common and cumulative. Most respondents who stopped buying cite quality not matching expectations, poor value for price, and influencer overuse as primary reasons. Disengagement reflects an expectation mismatch rather than single point failures.

Responses about what brands get wrong and what they should stop doing form a clear corrective blueprint. Stop using misleading visuals, stop relying on paid or excessive influencer signals as a substitute for product strength, stop chasing every viral micro trend at the expense of core identity, and rebalance growth focus toward retention and product consistency.

Taken together, the evidence in this section establishes the authenticity gap as a structural problem in the Indian D2C fashion market. Brands build perception through image led communication, while Gen Z applies a verification-based decision logic. Closing the gap requires aligning messaging with measurable delivery, protecting the integrity of peer validation, and prioritizing product and service fundamentals over amplification.

Conclusion for Data Interpretation and Analysis:

The dataset provides a sound basis for examining Gen Z engagement with Indian D2C fashion brands. Respondents are digitally active, largely students, and report recent purchase experience. Spending patterns indicate price sensitivity with limited premium tolerance, aligning well with the study objective of analysing awareness, perception, trust, and purchase logic among core D2C consumers.

The findings show that discovery and early attention are driven by platforms and visuals. Brand recall is concentrated among a small set of players. Visual aesthetics and product design capture interest, while price functions as an early screening factor. First impressions are generally positive but rarely decisive on their own.

Brand messaging achieves visibility but operates under credibility constraints. Trend focused and relatable communication often coexists with perceptions of overpromotion and artificiality. Alignment between messaging and experience is moderate rather than exceptional. Repeated exposure in algorithm driven environments, especially Instagram, contributes to rising scepticisms.

Trust formation occurs before purchase and relies on concrete signals. Product quality, customer reviews, brand image, and price dominate decision making. Customer reviews act as the primary validation mechanism. Disengagement most often occurs during review checks or website evaluation, not after product delivery. Influencer marketing supports awareness but has limited impact at the point of purchase.

The implications for D2C brands are clear. Visual appeal must be matched by delivery consistency. Review credibility requires protection and visibility. Communication should shift from amplification toward transparency, accuracy, and interaction. Instagram presence remains important for discovery but is insufficient for conversion without independent validation and reliable product performance.

In summary, the central issue is an authenticity gap between brand projection and consumer decision logic. Closing this gap requires aligning promises with delivery, safeguarding peer-based validation, and prioritizing product and service fundamentals over growth through amplification. This alignment is critical to reducing pre purchase disengagement and improving conversion among Gen Z consumers.

INSIGHTS AND RECOMMENDATION

INSIGHTS

- **Insights 1.** Gen Z demonstrates low baseline trust toward paid digital advertising.
The findings indicate that Gen Z consumers possess strong awareness of paid advertising mechanics, platform algorithms, and influencer compensation. As a result, paid social advertisements on platforms such as Instagram are quickly identified as commercial and transactional. Once content is recognized as paid, scepticisms increases and credibility declines. Attention is granted temporarily, but trust is withheld until external validation is available.
- **Insight 2.** Visual quality determines whether a brand is considered at all.
Gen Z uses visual cues as a primary screening mechanism. On Instagram, where content consumption is rapid, strong and consistent visual presentation earns a brief pause. This pause allows further evaluation, but it does not imply intent to purchase. Poor or generic visuals lead to immediate rejection, regardless of product claims. Visual appeal functions as an entry requirement rather than a differentiating factor.
- **Insight 3.** Price is evaluated in relation to perceived design and quality.
Gen Z assesses pricing alongside visual presentation. Products that appear well designed and reasonably priced are seen as potential value opportunities. High prices without established brand credibility raise suspicion, while low prices paired with weak visuals suggest inferior quality. Misalignment between price and presentation creates confusion and discourages purchase consideration.
- **Insight 4.** Many D2C brands are perceived as trend driven and interchangeable.
The analysis shows that Gen Z often views D2C brands as trend followers rather than identity driven brands. Repeated imitation of popular aesthetics, influencer formats, and social media trends reduces perceived uniqueness. When brands lack a stable identity, they are categorized as opportunistic, which negatively impacts long term loyalty.
- **Insight 5.** Authenticity is evaluated through consistency, not claims.
Gen Z defines authenticity through sustained alignment between product quality, pricing, communication tone, and customer experience. Symbolic efforts such as slogans, paid endorsements, or curated storytelling without operational consistency are rejected. Authenticity is assessed over time rather than through isolated campaigns.

- **Insight 6. Over produced content reduces credibility.**
Highly polished visuals, exaggerated messaging, and artificial narratives are perceived as manipulative. Gen Z responds more positively to direct language, realistic demonstrations, and acknowledgment of product limitations. Honest communication signals confidence and respect for consumer judgment.
- **Insight 7. Influencers support awareness but do not drive trust.**
The findings indicate that Gen Z understands influencer marketing economics. Influencers act as discovery channel's rather than trust sources. Final purchase decisions depend more on feedback from real customers who have no visible incentive to promote the brand.
- **Insight 8. Post purchase experience strongly shapes brand trust.**
Gen Z compares delivered product quality with pre purchase representation. When expectations are met or exceeded, trust increases. When there is a mismatch, dissatisfaction spreads quickly through peer networks. Since D2C brands lack physical retail presence, accurate representation becomes critical.
- **Insight 9. Customer reviews act as a risk reduction mechanism.**
Because D2C purchases occur entirely online, Gen Z relies heavily on genuine customer reviews to reduce uncertainty. Reviews serve as a substitute for physical product inspection and play a decisive role in purchase decisions.
- **Insight 10. Community visibility signals accountability and longevity.**
Active customer interaction, visible discussions, and shared experiences reduce perceived risk. A visible community indicates that the brand expects ongoing relationships rather than one-time transactions, which improves trust.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- Recommendation 1. Rebalance the role of paid advertising.
D2C brands should reduce overdependence on aggressive paid advertisements. Paid media should be used mainly for visibility and reach, while trust should be built through organic content such as real product usage, behind the scenes processes, and honest brand communication.
- Recommendation 2. Treat visual quality as a basic expectation.
Brands must maintain high and consistent visual standards across all digital platforms. Visual design should be clear, cohesive, and aligned with the brand identity, as strong visuals are necessary to gain initial attention on platforms like Instagram.
- Recommendation 3. Ensure pricing reflects perceived quality.
Product pricing should align closely with design quality and overall brand positioning. When price and presentation match, consumer evaluation becomes easier and trust increases.
- Recommendation 4. Build a stable brand identity before engaging with trends.
D2C brands should clearly define their values, voice, and visual style before adopting social media trends or collaborations. Trends should support the brand's identity rather than shape it.
- Recommendation 5. Build authenticity through consistency over time.
Authenticity should be demonstrated through consistent product quality, reliable service, and stable communication tone. Repeated actions are more effective in building trust than promotional claims.
- Recommendation 6. Communicate in a clear and honest manner.
Brands should avoid exaggerated promises and overly polished storytelling. Communication should focus on realistic product demonstrations, clear explanations, and transparent information about features and limitations.
- Recommendation 7. Use influencers only after brand identity is established.
Influencer collaborations should be used to amplify an already defined brand image. Influencers should support brand communication rather than act as the primary source of credibility.
- Recommendation 8. Match promotional messaging with actual product delivery.
Brands must ensure that product performance and quality match what is shown in advertisements and content. Consistency between expectation and delivery is essential to maintain consumer trust.
- Recommendation 9. Give priority to genuine customer feedback.
D2C brands should actively display authentic customer reviews, repeat purchase experiences, and balanced feedback. This helps reduce perceived risk and supports informed decision making.

- Recommendation 10. Focus on long term community development.

Brands should create spaces for customer interaction, discussion, and feedback. A visible and active community signals accountability and encourages long term relationships rather than one-time purchases.

CONCLUSION:

This study examined the gap between how Indian D2C fashion brands present themselves and how Gen Z consumers perceive, judge, and act on those presentations during purchase decisions. Across all sections of the research, one consistent insight emerges. For Gen Z, authenticity is not a message or a claim. It is an outcome assessed continuously through brand behaviour, consistency, and alignment between promise and delivery.

The study began by situating Indian D2C fashion within a fast-growing digital ecosystem shaped by social media reach, platform algorithms, and capital driven scale ambitions. Within this setting, Gen Z stands out as a consumer group with a distinct evaluation process. Discovery is rapid, exposure is constant, and trust is rarely assumed. The core issue identified early was misalignment. Many brands invest heavily in visuals, influencer partnerships, and value driven narratives, while falling short on product consistency, pricing logic, customer experience, and follow through. This mismatch becomes a source of scepticism rather than inspiration.

The research objectives focused on understanding how Gen Z makes decisions, where perception gaps form, how trust weakens, and why disengagement and brand switching occur. These objectives were addressed through a structured research design grounded in real purchase experience. By restricting the sample to Gen Z consumers with recent D2C fashion interactions, the analysis reflects lived behaviours rather than hypothetical attitudes.

The literature review supported this direction by framing authenticity as something operational and observable. Prior research emphasizes social proof, peer validation, and consistent brand behaviour as central to Gen Z trust. At the same time, limited work connects authenticity directly to disengagement outcomes in the Indian D2C fashion space. This study contributes by linking authenticity perception to decision logic and exit behaviour.

The analysis reveals clear and repeatable patterns. Gen Z approaches paid advertising with caution and understands the commercial nature of influencer content. Visual appeal determines whether a brand is noticed, not whether it is trusted. Price is judged against perceived quality and brand maturity rather than discounts alone. Excessive trend chasing and influencer dependence weaken brand identity. Trust develops primarily through delivery and peer feedback, not promotional claims. Reviews and community responses function as risk reduction tools in an online only purchase environment.

The findings show that Gen Z does not dismiss brands outright. What they reject is inconsistency, exaggeration, and performative authenticity. Brands that communicate clearly, behave predictably, and deliver on expectations retain credibility. Advertising and influencers draw attention but fail to replace proof. Identity needs to exist before amplification rather than being built through promotion.

The recommendations focus on structural adjustments rather than surface fixes. Brands need to reduce dependence on paid visibility, treat visual quality as a minimum standard, align pricing with delivered value, maintain a stable brand identity, and protect the integrity of customer feedback. These changes address the causes of distrust rather than its symptoms.

Overall, the study shows that authenticity within India's D2C fashion market is a structural challenge, not a communication flaw. For Gen Z, trust forms through alignment between what a brand communicates, what it presents visually, and what it delivers in practice. Brands prioritizing short term visibility over long term credibility face early disengagement and rising acquisition pressure. Brands embedding authenticity into product, experience, and accountability are better positioned for repeat purchase, loyalty, and organic advocacy.

This research adds academic value by positioning authenticity as an observable decision variable and offers managerial relevance by framing it as a discipline rooted in execution rather than expression.

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